Statecraft, Sovereignty & Digital Government

Symposium Programme & Abstracts

16–17 April 2026 · Goldsmiths, University of London

Hosted by the DIGI-FRONT Project · Co-hosted by Nathaniel Tkacz, Goldsmiths

Programme

THURSDAY, 16 APRIL			
11:30–13:00	**Infrastructural Power & Politics I** • Bastian Manteuffel • Julia Valeska Schröder • Gavin Duffy • Nika Mahnic	**AI in the State, Expertise & Legitimacy I** • Alexander Campolo • Anuradha Sajjanhar • Becky Kazansky & Lina Dencik • Siddharth de Souza, Emrys Schoemaker & Thomas Kirk	**Digital Sovereignty in Theory & Practice I** • Janine Patricia Santos • Sandeep Mertia • Frederik Schade • Ida Marie Iversen & Maja Hvarregaard Pedersen • Samuele Fratini
14:20–15:50	**Authoritarian Currents I** • Dmitry Kuznetsov & Alex Gekker • Gregory Asmolov • Roei Davidson	**AI in the State, Expertise & Legitimacy II** • Chiara Poletti • David Moats • Freyja van den Boom • Dominik Piétron	**Digital Sovereignty: Alternatives & Lock-ins I** • Roser Pujads & Daniel Curto-Millet • Lasse Uhrskov Kristensen • Emilie Mørch Groth • Gianmarco Cristofari
16:10–17:40	**Authoritarian Currents II** • Lianrui Jia & Ting Luo • Ruth Garland • Anirban Mukhopadhyay • Roger Burrows & Nicholas Gane	**Digital Transformation I** • Jess Brand • Petter Falk • Krystian Łukasik & Renata Włoch • Nathan Davies	**Digital Sovereignty in Theory & Practice II** • Joao C. Magalhaes & Edemilson Parana • Marguerite Borelli • Clara Iglesias Keller & Julia Pohle
FRIDAY, 17 APRIL			
09:30–11:00	**Infrastructural Power & Politics II** • Bidisha Chaudhuri & Sookthi Kav • Matilde Bro • Loup Cellard & Clément Marquet • Dan M. Kotliar & Alex Gekker	**Citizens, Users & Citizenship** • Rachel Humphris & Nika Mahnič • Zhou Pei • Oisín O'Brien • Keren Weitzberg, Margie Cheesman, Aaron Martin, Hanna Stoll &	**Digital Transformation II** • Torjus Solheim Eckhoff • Karine Côté-Boucher & Mireille Paquet • Jessamy Perriam • Margarita Boenig-Liptsin
11:10–12:40	**Digital Transformation III** • Mait Kask, Andra Siibak & Maris Männiste • Sruthi Vanguri • Carina R. Nasser & Mattéo Bard • Alexei Tsinovoi & Ask Greve	**Digital Sovereignty: Alternatives & Lock-ins II** • Matilde Bro, Rebecca Adler-Nissen & Kristin Anabel Eggeling • Dr Paloma Viejo Otero & Dr Eugenia Siapera • Matt Spencer • Gro Stueland Skorpen	**Digital Sovereignty: Alternatives & Lock-ins III** • Oscar Arruda d'Alva, Rodrigo Santaella-Gonçalves & Edemilson Paraná • Eva Iris Otto, Sofie Flensburg & Signe Sophus Lai • Damiano Razzoli & Nicola Casucci
14:00	**Final Keynotes & Roundtable**		
16:00	**Close of Symposium**		

Abstracts by Panel

Infrastructural Power & Politics I

Bastian Manteuffel

Infrastructural politics in the digital administrative state: Municipal agency under fragmented governance conditions. The availability of digital administrative services is routinely mobilized as an indicator for modern state-ness (see European Commission, 2025; Barry, 2001). In Germany, efforts to transform internal state affairs by means of digital technologies have been characterized as both institutionally, and infrastructurally fragmented, with the lack of progress usually discussed as a governance problem of vertical, and horizontal coordination. In this view, administrative digitization is a heterogenous phenomenon contested also between state actors lacking articulation as on how it ought to be realized and what it should solve. This is particularly visible at the municipal level which delivers the majority of administrative services, yet is granted constitutional autonomy over how this is done. Rather than problematizing the implementation per se, this paper is interested in how the German case reveals how digital state-making is not a monolithic state activity but unfolds across institutional, and infrastructural spaces. While institutional conditions provide the backdrop of responsibilities, and intergovernmental communication, infrastructural elements function both as sites of contestation, where local demands, and autonomy are negotiated, and as modes of governing, either through technical standards, or the "installed base" (Aanestad et al., 2017). Drawing on an ongoing research project (2021-), this paper traces digital state-making through municipal digital building permits, digital planning, and an internal modernization project, showing how tensions on the infrastructural layer revolve around issues of translation, institutional shifts, and temporality. This paper looks at these phenomena in terms of infrastructural politics governed by uncertainty. While existing research has revealed the highly consequential politics of digital administrative practice (Peeters & Widlak, 2023; Abdu & Jacobs, 2024; Ranchordas, 2021), this paper emphasizes the mundane, often unfinished activities of digital infrastructuring. If indeed, future states increasingly appear as infrastructural stacks, where democratic, and bureaucratic values are displaced along wider sociotechnical networks, it seems, that these phenomena require scholarly attention even when their social consequences can not be immediately assessed.

Julia Valeska Schröder

While the ever more explicit etatization of Digital Transformation is intensified through high-tech “GovTech”, also analyses of digital statecraft tend to focus on digital technologies as transformative force of the state (e.g. Berg & Hofmann, 2021; Fourcade & Gordon, 2020; Katzenbach & Ulbricht, 2019; Wong, 2021). However, the simultaneous advancement of digital politics is crucial to understand the more-than-digital (Klausner, 2022) dimensions digital statecraft. This contribution emphasizes the role of institutionalized digital politics for governmental technologies of Digital Transformation: The enactment of crisis narratives, used to portray the state as being at risk and legitimizing new (re)forms and (infra)structures; the conceptualization of ‚digital sovereignty‘ as reinterpretation of state power in the digital constellation (Berg et al., 2020) to reclaim authority over socio-political developments; as well as the operationalization of technopolitical modes that specify the practices of transformation and thereby the relationships between technology and politics. Not least, digital political statecraft deconstructs “the state” as a structural effect (Abrams, 1988) by turning the constituent relational infrastructures and their social and processual character outward; enacting “the state” no longer solely in formal political registers, but as fragile, processual infrastructural achievement – thus visibilizing the material and socio-technical foundations of state power. Based on an ethnographic study of the Public Innovation Lab in Berlin (CityLAB), I develop the concept of ‘intrastatecraft’ to highlight a specific programmatic shift away from technocentric approaches. Intrastatecraft is characterized by techniques of craft-like ‘intraventions’ in infrastructural-administrative situations (Birkbak & Papazu, 2022). So-called „public changemakers“ act locally on the affective, “poetic” (Larkin, 2013) entanglements of administrative infrastructures. They experiment with their embedding within other (infra)structures, with the community of users, and with cultural conventions of use (Star, 1999) in order to participate in the infrastructuring power within the executive processes of the state The Prefix “intra” thus highlights the importance of understanding governmental technologies beyond Foucault (2009, 2022) as the interaction with the formal boundaries of political government and governing of the practitioners of state administration. Further, paying closer attention to the component craft, ‘intrastatecraft’ aims to sensitize for statecrafting – the situated, skillful, experimental and creative production of power relations.

Gavin Duffy

Digital governance made material: AI data centres and local communities The rise of AI in recent years, in both cultural and political imaginaries, has resulted in a great deal of discussion around the future of democracy and sovereignty, whether through the direct use of AI systems in governance (such as the UK government’s Red Box) or the more indirect but no less important influence of AI boosters in setting political agendas (Gebru and Torres, 2024). At the same time, there has been an increasing focus on the material infrastructure required to support these AI imaginaries, particularly data centres. This is seen again in policy (e.g. the UK government’s planned AI Growth Zones) and in academic with this literature focusing on how this infrastructure can be examined critically and resisted locally literature (e.g. Rone, 2024; Lehuedé, 2025). This raises questions around sovereignty for local communities and, in particular, for Indigenous populations in many countries whose land and water rights are often threatened by the construction of data centres. This presentation will detail critical AI data centre studies, as part of the findings of a scoping review of this field, focusing on empirical data collection and analysis. In turn, this paper will present empirical findings from the author on local resistance to data centres in London, asking what parallels can be drawn (if any) and what issues may be spatially specific. Thus, in contrast to larger policy debates focusing on sovereignty at the national or international levels (e.g. in the EU), this presentation will address the question of how what sovereignty means in an age of AI at a local, community level. This will present the need for a focus on the ‘everyday’ of AI, generating a non-digital-centric idea of digital governance using the framework of AI

justice.

Nika Mahnic

The indentured state: programmable infrastructures and the loss of infrastructural power The public/private boundary often limits theoretical insight, with calls for public values in publicly funded infrastructures (Taylor, 2021) falling short of the long-lasting enmeshment of the public and private. I address the enmeshment of the public and the private with reference to the 'governmental sphere', composed of public and private actors collaborating on the ways of governing the state (Weiss, 2019, pp. 6-15). In my PhD project, I analysed the contemporary relevance of the imaginaries of management consultants (de)forming the British state since the nineteenth century onwards — their role in state (de)formation since the birth of the British Civil Service. More recently, reading into digital transformation through Brett Christophers's forms of rentierism (Christophers, 2022) the thesis illuminates the various forms of rent pursuant to the building of the British "programmable infrastructures" (Gürses et al., 2020). In that way, digital statecraft can be seen as a way of advancing the interests of the governmental sphere. Building on interdisciplinary secondary literature, grey literature and archival records, I expand Dencik's concept of the "tenant state" (2022, p. 161), contributing the concept of 'the indentured state.' Analysing 'the indentured state' as a political formation and a condition enables us to clarify the consequences of transforming the state(s) digitally, beyond the flows of rent harvested by the governmental sphere. Referring to the state as a condition, 'the indentured state' refers to the state of being captive; to digital transformation, contracts, workfare and indebtedness. A historically-informed analysis of the British welfare state (Bhambra, 2021; Lewis, 2000), focused on a political economy of risk assessment, reveals how Others have been subjected to a double indenture, while some have been signing generous long-term infrastructure contracts.

Infrastructural Power & Politics II

Matilde Bro

Title: Sovereignty by design: AI gigafactories, public-private partnerships and Europe's infrastructural 'turn' Abstract: Sovereignty by design: AI gigafactories, public-private partnerships and Europe's infrastructural 'turn' Matilde Bro, PhD-student, University of Copenhagen, Department of Political Science mbha@ifs.ku.dk This article examines how digital sovereignty in the European Union (EU) is designed and co-produced by EU institutions, (member) states and private consortia's through public private partnerships. Through a case study of the EU Commissions launch of the so-called AI gigafactories, a public-private partnerships initiated to establish supercomputing ecosystems across five of EU's member states to store data, attract talent and develop advanced (European) AI models, I contribute with new insights to how the processes, relations and practices of building AI infrastructure design and co-produce digital sovereignty in Europe. Designing such a European alternative to American digital infrastructure, which European citizens, companies and governments are deeply dependent on embodies Europe's infrastructural 'turn', positioning digital infrastructure as a geopolitical asset and a site of contestation between private and public actors over who should own and operate it. Drawing on Science & Technology studies (STS) and International Relations' (IR) infrastructural 'turn', I conceptualize these AI gigafactories as public private partnerships of (geo)political infrastructures that (re)order space, authority and identity. I argue that EU's AI gigafactories operate on two levels: material – embodying sovereignty in physical supercomputing capacity, certifications and standards; and narrative – seeking security-of-self for Europe as a technological actor amid global dependencies. Through these levels, I identity three sovereignty dilemmas of control, territorialization and membership. Empirically, the article draws on

ethnographic fieldwork in Brussels, combining participant observation, semi-structured interviews with EU's digital policymakers and industry actors as well as document analysis of official material (policy paper, statements, speeches) released by EU institutions, (member) states and companies between 2023 and 2025. The multi-sited approach reveals how infrastructural governance becomes a site of identity-making and geopolitical positioning contributing to the literature on sovereignty, security and sociotechnical imaginaries.

Loup Cellard & Clément Marquet

How public-private relations shape the ordering of digital infrastructures? Between 2018 and 2024, the American company Digital Realty constructed four data centers at the Marseille-Fos Port, an industrial hub located on the northern coast of Marseille, France. The port seized the opportunity presented by the city's rapidly growing status in global data exchanges. Indeed, over the past decade, Marseille has ascended from 44th to 5th place among the world's most connected cities. This new status has garnered particular interest from the port's main shareholder, the French government, which aims to transform the site into a strategic asset for enhancing national digital sovereignty. In this context, we wonder how the (mis)alignment of interests between regional State agencies and private infrastructural actors shape the ordering of data centers and subsea telecom cables in Marseille (France)? We have identified three phases that illustrate the complex relationships between the State and private actors involved. Firstly, prior to 2021, the development of digital infrastructures in Marseille was not a matter for the state but for the private sector only. Digital Realty aimed at transforming Marseille into a key data exchange hub. This resulted in two things: the arrival of major clients such as Microsoft and Disney+; a strong financial investment in the construction of a connection gate facilitating the plugging within the industrial port of submarine cables into data centres. Secondly, between 2021 and 2023, local elected officials and state agencies began to contest the massive rise of data centres and submarine cables within the city. The prefecture (which represents the State at the regional level) brought the various stakeholders together to find compromises and facilitate the work of Digital Realty and other data centre operators. Here, the prefecture (and therefore the State) seem to be facilitating the work of the private sector — despite the fact that local elected officials never fully understood the State's sovereignty strategy. Thirdly, since 2024, within regional state agencies, the call to promote national sovereignty began to be productive but remain fragile: the way in which cables are laid has been redefined; the city's urban planning agency has produced recommendations to improve the urban integration of data centres. The case of Marseille shows how the alignment between the public and private sectors is never complete and that the national slogan of sovereignty is struggling to fully push local State actors to regulate infrastructural work. Ultimately, private players such as Digital Realty remain the main actor ordering the ways infrastructures are developed in the city.

Dan M. Kotliar & Alex Gekker

Contested Clouds: Digital Sovereignty and the Politics of National Data Infrastructure in Israel/Palestine Recent scholarship has called for the 'comprehensive democratisation of digital sovereignty' (Rone 2023, 1), positioning citizen participation as central to equitable cloud infrastructure governance. Yet, this call presumes a shared understanding of what sovereignty means and whose 'matters-of-concern' (Latour 2004; 2005) data infrastructures should serve. This paper examines Israel's Project Nimbus, a $1.2 billion national initiative to "migrate the state" into GCP and AWS (Kotliar and Gekker 2024), to explore how digital sovereignty is contested, claimed, and refused by divergent publics (Thielmann and Borbach 2025). Drawing on discourse analysis of government documents, corporate communications, news press, and activist media, we trace three distinct contestations of what Nimbus is. First, we show how Google and Amazon worked to naturalise their data centres as benign matters of fact through techno-nationalist imagery, framing the cloud as operating "on Israel's terms" while strategically obscuring their global cloud empires. Second, we examine how Israeli residents and military figures reframed Nimbus through securitised imaginaries: not as an environmental threat (as in Dutch or Irish national cases), but as vulnerable national infrastructure exposed to missile attacks and cyber threats. Third, we analyse the #NoTechForApartheid campaign, which mobilised a transnational counterpublic around Nimbus as an instrument of occupation and human rights abuse. These contestations reveal digital sovereignty as a floating signifier (Glasze et al. 2023; Couture et al. 2024), claimed simultaneously bythe state (jurisdictional control), local residents (protection from external threats), and international activists (ethical accountability). Rather than converging on deliberative co-production, these publics talk past one another, their attachments to the cloud shaped by incommensurable concerns. The paper concludes by asking what democratic governance of cloud infrastructure can mean when the "shape of the cloud" itself is so thoroughly contested: as the same data centres appear as tools of globalised progress, threatened national assets, and shadows of occupation, depending on one's vantage point.

AI in the State, Expertise & Legitimacy I

Alexander Campolo

Action: AI-enabled Government in the UK. A literature on AI and government has recently made promises to identify "a new national purpose" (Blair and Hague 2023) or "a new model to transform the state" (Iosad et al., 2024). And in January 2025, the Labour government of the United Kingdom duly presented its "AI Opportunities Action Plan," to Parliament (Clifford 2025). This presentation analyses the emerging political logic of such calls to "action" on AI. Despite nostalgic references to mid-twentieth century industrial policy and personal connection to the New Labour's neoliberal wing, I argue that contemporary reflection on AI and government operates within a political context that has substantially transformed, marked by new geopolitical divisions and mercantilist rivalries. Rather than representing an irrationalist rejection of expertise in favour of culture war issues, AI makes a politicised "claim to techné"—a privileged competence for delivering what citizens, here theorised as a single, disaffected body of consumers of government services, desire (Bickerton and Invernizzi Accetti 2021, 31). This "technopopulist" reflection on AI and government further speculates on how AI will deliver services. Somewhat counter-intuitively, these

proposals depart from a calculative, bureaucratic logic that has long linked computers and technocratic administration (Agar 2003). Nor do they represent, as some left-leaning scholars may hope, a renewed form of democratic planning (Durand et al. 2024; Benanav 2025). Above all, AI, in the form of digital government assistants, promises to radically disintermediate service provision, constituting a direct interface between the individual citizen and the state, now encoded into the parameters of machine learning models. Together, these transformations point to a shift in the relationship between politics and expertise. Displacing both bureaucratic inertia and neoliberal market failures, AI makes ambiguous political claims to renew social democracy through "delivery."

Anuradha Sajjanhar

Artificial Intelligence is no longer a speculative frontier in UK governance but an operational reality across domains such as welfare, immigration, and health. While policy discourse often frames these technologies in techno-optimistic terms, promising efficiency, productivity, and more “human” services, their integration into the state is reshaping foundational questions of expertise, authority, and legitimacy. This paper develops the concept of AI as epistemic infrastructure to analyse these transformations. By epistemic infrastructure, I refer to the layered interplay of data practices, algorithmic systems, institutional routines, and discursive framings through which authority is stabilised and knowledge rendered actionable in governance. This approach shifts analytical focus from questions of algorithmic bias or technical performance to the broader epistemic conditions under which decisions are defined, justified, and legitimated. Empirically, the UK provides a critical case study. Positioned outside the EU AI Act, the UK has adopted a pro-innovation regulatory stance while simultaneously outsourcing technical capacity to private firms such as Palantir, Microsoft, and AWS. Preliminary findings from interviews and documentary analysis reveal a fragmented and opaque landscape in which AI systems are frequently introduced without settled frameworks of oversight, often uncovered only through Freedom of Information requests. The consequence is a redistribution of epistemic authority: civil servants’ discretion and professional judgement are increasingly subordinated to computational models and private technical expertise. The paper argues that this reconfiguration of expertise carries significant implications for democratic governance. AI systems not only mediate how policy problems are defined and prioritised, but also embed normative assumptions into administrative routines, narrowing the space for deliberation and contestation. By examining AI as epistemic infrastructure, I highlight the need to reconceptualise expertise as a site of political struggle, and to foreground accountability and democratic legitimacy in debates on digital governance.

Becky Kazansky & Lina Dencik

Title: Tracing the co-production of AI demand in corporate and governmental discourses. Abstract: In the corporate language of their recent environmental sustainability reports, Big Tech companies characterise their current work to develop AI as one of duty to respond however possible to an overwhelming demand for AI ‘out there’ in the world. This duty, in turn, justifies reneging on responsibilities such as previous climate commitments, superfluous in any case, because AI is a primary solution to the climate crisis itself. The national AI strategies of countries working closely with these companies — such as the UK, the United States, and Canada — speak, on the other hand, of an obligation for governments to ‘keep up’ with AI developments. Keeping up means encouraging AI adoption across all sectors of society, whether through support for the buildout of new data centres and energy infrastructure, to the deepening integration of AI applications into public services and education. Amidst the spectre of an AI ‘bubble’ threatening to pop, this paper explores how corporate and governmental actors construct the idea of an unrelenting societal demand for AI which must be met through any means possible. The paper bases its findings on a discourse analysis of corporate sustainability reports, national AI strategy documents, and a tranche of government transparency documents demonstrating the scale of corporate lobbying by Big Tech companies. By analysing these documents together, the paper tracks how an agentic dance of duty and obligation serves to rationalise, naturalise, and justifiy current AI trajectories at national scales.

AI in the State, Expertise & Legitimacy II

Chiara Poletti

Digital statecraft from below? AI governance and democratic oversight in Welsh local government As debates on digital sovereignty intensify across Europe, much attention has focused on national strategies and supranational coordination (Falkner et al., 2024). Yet sub-national and devolved governments also navigate questions of technological dependency, public value, and democratic oversight. This contribution examines AI adoption in Welsh local government: a site where devolved governance, public service transformation, and participatory traditions intersect. Despite growing AI adoption in its public services, the UK lacks binding horizontal AI legislation, and public sector AI use continues to outpace regulatory clarity (Public Law Project, 2024). Legal safeguards are difficult to apply (Lazcoz & De Hert, 2023). Even "assistive" technologies adopted in public services have proved to change the ways in which the state operates, reshaping institutional workflows and professional judgement, embedding bias, and limiting transparency (Eubanks, 2018; Dencik et al., 2022). Participatory approaches are often proposed as mitigation, but implementation faces serious challenges: time pressures, uneven digital confidence, and organisational hierarchies can limit meaningful involvement of workers and marginalised groups (Connected by Data, 2025). This contribution asks: 1) How does local AI adoption reconfigure state capacity in a devolved context? 2) What forms of democratic oversight are feasible under real-world constraints? Wales offers a distinctive case: its governance is explicitly oriented toward public value through the Well-being of Future Generations (Wales) Act 2015, and the Welsh government’s Centre for Digital Public Services (CDPS) is developing significant co-production experiences in the digitalisation of public services. The contribution presents an initial mapping of AI-related initiatives across South Wales local authorities and a synthesis of co-production and participatory governance initiatives in Welsh public services. The Welsh case thus offers a vantage point for examining how digital statecraft operates at sub-national scales, and what forms of sovereignty and

participation remain possible within nested governance arrangements.

David Moats

Chatbot Democracy: The emerging role of LLMs in digital democracy platforms. In 2023, OpenAI, creator of Chat GPT, funded 10 teams from around the world to prototype scalable solutions for participation in AI Development. Although many saw the Democratic Inputs programme as participation washing (Sloane et al), more “market research” than participatory governance, several of the teams involved were civic tech experts who used the money to trial new techniques for digital democracy platforms more generally. These techniques included LLM summarized text, LLM moderated focus groups and penetrating interviews designed to extract the participants’ “underlying values.” Many of these teams went on to embed these AI driven technologies in bespoke digital democracy software which is currently being rolled out by governments. Although the point of the exercise was to evaluate these new “participatory devices,” this was often done quantitatively either using fairness measures or user surveys. This paper draws on work from Science and Technology Studies (Lezaun et al 2007) and Valuation Studies to analyse and compare these experiments in a different light. It employs methods from digital controversy analysis (Moats and Tseng 2023) to study how these experiments with AI 'format' participation: using data produced by the teams and interviews with team members. The paper asks what happens when opinions are aggregated and analysed not through voting but through LLMs? What kinds of interviewers are LLMs? What types of participants or modes of participation are presumed by these techniques? What might standard evaluation metrics mask about the process? Lezaun, J. (2007). A market of opinions: The political epistemology of focus groups. The Sociological Review, 55, 130–151. Moats, D., & Tseng, Y.-S. (2023). Sorting a public? Using quali-quantitative methods to interrogate the role of algorithms in digital democracy platforms. Information, Communication & Society, 1–35. https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2023.2230286 Sloane, M., Moss, E., Awomolo, O., & Forlano, L. (2020). Participation is not a Design Fix for Machine Learning (No. arXiv:2007.02423). arXiv. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2007.02423

Freyja van den Boom

Regulatory Capture and Futures Imaginaries of Digital Sovereignty Abstract: "I cannot generate that image." When a chatbot refuses to render the female nipple in the context of artistic research, it is not merely content moderation; it is an act of governance. The platform has defined the normative, enforcing a privatized moral code that supersedes local legal or cultural contexts. This paper argues that as governments rush to integrate Generative AI into public services, they are not just purchasing software; they are outsourcing the power to define reality, effectively ceding digital sovereignty to corporate imaginaries. To dismantle the narratives of the AI Arms Race that justifies this regulatory capture, this paper introduces the Insight Catalyst through Causal Layered Tetrad Analysis (CLTA). This novel framework adopts speculative design, futures studies across disciplines to interrogate the AI Race through four layers. 1. Litany:The surface urgency of "staying ahead" geopolitically, which masks the reality of dependency on US-centric tech giants. 2. Systemic: How proprietary "GovTech" creates a lock-in where private terms of service functionally act as public law, obsolescing democratic oversight. 3. Worldview: The clash between Techno-Solutionism which views social friction as a bug to be fixed, and democratic pluralism. 4. Myth: The deconstruction of the "Genie out of the bottle" metaphor which frames corporate AI as an inevitable force of nature rather than a product of specific economic choices.]By analyzing what the AI race enhances (corporate efficiency) versus what it reverses into (a censored, homogenized public sphere) this paper challenges the inevitability of the current model.It proposes that digital government requires retrieving the "civic" in software, moving beyond the fear of falling behind to question who is setting the pace, and whose norms are being encoded into the state’s digital infrastructure. Keywords: Causal Layered Tetrad Analysis; Regulatory Capture; Digital Sovereignty; AI Censorship; GovTech Imaginaries.

Authoritarian Currents I

Dmitry Kuznetsov & Alex Gekker

Developing Our Own Solutions: Russia's Sovereign AI Import Substitution as Digital Statecraft. Russia’s federal AI project is a prominent case study of the intersection between geopolitical pressure, frontier technological development, and state power (Glasze et al. 2023). Adopted in 2019, it embodies a strategic logic of AI development in the context of global competition, and under domestic constraints further exacerbated by sanctions on import of advanced hardware and financial transactions (Niskanen 2023). As reducing strategic interdependence and building production capacity become explicit state policy, the state becomes guarantor of access to restricted resources — actively shaping domestic technology industries. The national scope of the endeavour renders the dynamic visible. The state is not developing its own tools, nor does it rely solely on regulation of private companies who provide off-the-shelf solutions for public ICT systems. By becoming the guarantor of access, the state creates the domestic industry suited to its needs and expectations, coordinating various actors (developers, researchers, civil service) through the aforementioned strategic logic. Empirically, we explore this logic through document analysis of Russia's federal AI portal (ai.gov.ru), which maps legal frameworks, ecosystem actors, R&D coordination, and funding streams. The portal functions both as dataset and as artifact of statecraft — performing state capacity while coordinating arrangements between government and companies like Yandex and Sber. This mapping allows us to challenge existing frameworks of state-corporate dependencies (Rone 2023; Kotliar and Gekker 2024; Cath 2025). While Russia operates an authoritarian system, such reconsideration prompts broader engagement with how state power operates within AI ecosystems (Van der Vlist et al. 2024): exerted both as regulator of industry and as facilitator of the country’s developmental efforts. Through this, we draw lessons for addressing dependence on foreign technology solutions, as calls for domestic alternatives permeate European policy debates (Desmarais 2025), and measures for reducing reliance on non-EU third parties are formalised across supply chains, operations, and technology stacks (European Commission 2025).

Gregory Asmolov

Authoritarian Diffusion and the Rise of AI Sovereignty. Disconnection and fragmentation are central to the strategies of authoritarian states seeking to maintain their resilience and eliminate threats to legitimacy. These regimes deploy various forms of disconnective power (Light, 2014) to fragment systems and construct new barriers within the digital domain. In this context, the growing dominance of sovereignty as a framework for governing digital platforms can be understood as part of a broader process of authoritarian diffusion. At the same time, certain expressions of sovereignty address legitimate concerns related to socio-cultural and individual autonomy, as well as to mitigating risks associated with the platform economy and the rise of surveillance capitalism. Digital sovereignty, therefore, stands between Scylla and Charybdis, caught between the expansion of digital authoritarianism and the currents of surveillance capitalism. The key challenge is to distinguish between forms of digital sovereignty that result from authoritarian diffusion and those driven by efforts to protect user agency and socio-cultural autonomy. This issue becomes particularly significant in the context of AI governance, where the notion of “AI sovereignty” has emerged as a defining concept for both authoritarian and democratic states. It forms a central element of AI governance frameworks developed by the BRICS countries, which together represent more than half of the world’s population. The paper offers a critical reflection on how AI sovereignty can be driven by authoritarian states and suggests that this reflexivity may help mitigate authoritarian diffusion in the field of AI governance. Based on an analysis of Russian narratives concerning AI governance and documents presented by BRICS countries, the talk identifies parallels between the communicative strategies employed by the USSR during the Cold War in regulating nuclear weapons as part of the arms race and the strategies now applied to the regulation of AI.

Roei Davidson

[Title] The Israeli IT Industry’s political interventions in the context of democratic backsliding and protracted war [Abstract] This study relies on an analysis of Israeli parliament (Knesset) committee debates taking place in 2023-2024 to consider the Israeli Information Technology (IT) Industry’s public intervention in the political sphere against the background of an authoritarian turn and protracted war. I consider how industry actors discuss in a public parliamentary setting their reaction to increased authoritarianism and war, whether in the form of civic activism (voice), emigration (exit) (Hirschman, 1970) or accommodation (neglect) (Withey & Cooper, 1989). Senior IT industry executives participated in the Knesset constitutional affairs committee related to government efforts to further neuter the independence of the judiciary, opposing them while not calling for a broader reassessment of the ongoing authoritarian turn in Israel. In parallel, in another committee, IT industry actors mostly seeked out accommodation: government policies which would compensate the industry financially for the growing difficulties the industry is encountering in raising funding from international sources and recruiting employees. This suggests that IT industry activism often morphs into industrial lobbying. The analysis of Knesset committee debates suggests that the IT industry which possesses high levels of economic and symbolic capital within a highly unequal society (Davidson, Rein & Tamir, 2024) discursively structures its intervention in political debates in a manner that protects its privileged economic position while constituting a partially missed opportunity to meaningfully reinforce liberal democracy within the Israeli polity. [References] Davidson, R., Rein, N., & Tamir, E. (2024). The time-making capacity of the technology industry and its consequences for public life. Journal of Cultural Economy, 17(1), 55–72. Hirschman, A. O. (1970). Exit, voice, and loyalty: Responses to decline in firms, organizations, and states. Harvard University Press. Withey, M. J., & Cooper, W. H. (1989). Predicting Exit, Voice, Loyalty, and Neglect. Administrative Science Quarterly, 34(4), 521–539.

Authoritarian Currents II

Lianrui Jia & Ting Luo

Title: From Connectivity to Sovereignty: Historicising China’s Digital Statecraft Abstract: Over the past three decades, China’s trajectory in digital government and technological development has shifted from belated connectivity to an assertive model of digital sovereignty. Wired to the global internet as the 71st country in 1994, China initially approached digital technologies through relative openness, market experimentation and developmental pragmatism. Yet across successive phases of digital transformation, from early portal websites in the 2000s to the rise of platform companies in the 2010s and today’s AI ecosystem, digital technologies have increasingly become instruments of statecraft used to consolidate political authority, reshape markets, and project geopolitical influence. This project develops a historical account of China’s digital statecraft that highlights three linked transitions structured around a dynamic between the different levels of government, capital markets, and rapidly growing technology companies. First, the early 2000s brought foreign investment, dot-com entrepreneurialism, and hybrid state–industry arrangements that sought to emulate Silicon Valley’s innovation model while adapting it to domestic political and economic priorities. Second, the expansion of powerful platform firms introduced tensions between market liberalisation, financialisation, and state sovereignty, prompting regulators to formalise and assert control over data flows, platform governance, and financial activities. Third, China’s AI-oriented industrial strategy reframes digital transformation as a strategic resource in global competition, with AI, data governance, and domestic cloud infrastructures deployed for both public service delivery and industrial upgrading. Across these transitions, China has built a sovereignty-centred governance model that operates through control of infrastructure, standards, content, and code. Much like “sovereignty as a service,” which global tech firms and AI vendors market to governments as modular tools of control (Grohmann and Costa Barbosa 2025), China articulates sovereignty as a comprehensive model of governance. This model offers an attractive reference point for some illiberal states, yet it remains challenging to reproduce due to China’s distinctive political economy and administrative capacity.

Ruth Garland

‘It’s not trivial, so don’t forget government communications’: why handing control of government digital tools to governing politicians is not in the public interest. The outcomes of a longitudinal study of UK government communications from 1979 to date finds that substantive and troubling long-term changes have taken place in the ways governments manage the media and publicly account for themselves that has progressively undermined the public consent essential to democracy (Garland, 2021). The Government Communications Service (GCS) is internally regulated, with no enforcement mechanisms, while successive restructures have taken place without public discussion. Panicked decisions made in the face of career-threatening media scrutiny has led to intended and unintended consequences that challenge the capacity of central public bureaucracies to deploy digital forms of communication in order to implement public values and maintain impartiality. During Covid, the misuse of WhatsApp in government was exposed during the Covid-19 inquiry. Less well known is Rishi Sunak’s misuse while Chancellor of official Treasury social media channels to conduct a personal branding campaign that positioned him as a future PM (Garland, 2026, under review). In 2023, the OECD’s first Public Communications Scan for the UK recommended “a transparent, independent oversight mechanism to ensure propriety and trustworthiness” and proposed a citizens’ charter for communication and engagement” (OECD, 2023). No evidence for this is forthcoming. In July 2025, in a structural change that came suddenly and without public debate, the Labour government appointed a former Sun editor into the new (impartial) role of Permanent Secretary, Government Communications to “take advantage of the rapidly evolving media landscape” during this “pivotal moment”, to deliver Starmer’s ‘Plan for Change’ (GCS 2025). It is argued that the government's public communication function, both political and impartial, is a digital leadership resource that must be transparently regulated in the public interest. References Garland, R (2021). Government Communications and the Crisis of Trust: From Political Spin to Post-truth. Cham. Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan. Garland, R (2026, under review). Executing a personal political branding campaign from within government: the case of the UK finance minister Rishi Sunak and social media (2020-22). Journal of Political Marketing. GCS/Cabinet Office (2025). Permanent Secretary Director of Communications appointed. 30th July. https://www.gov.uk/government/news/permanent-secretary-director-of-communications-appointed OECD (2023). Public Communication Scan of the United Kingdom. OECD Public Governance Reviews. https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/public-communication-scan-of-the-united-kingdom_bc4a57b3-en.html Author: Ruth Garland, Lecturer, Goldsmiths, University of London - r.garland@gold.ac.uk

Anirban Mukhopadhyay

Between Cybersecurity and Surveillance: “Sanchar Sathi” Application and India's Digital Governmentality This paper investigates the digital governance initiative launched by the government of India that mandates the pre-installation of the “Sanchar Sathi” application on every mobile phone in India. According to the Indian Ministry of Information Rule, users cannot remove this application, and the Indian government has asked phone manufacturers to embed this technology through phone updates. The government's rationale for installing the “Sanchar Sathi” application hinges on ensuring citizens’ cybersecurity, protecting against cyberfraud, and authenticating mobile handsets. This paper explores how this mandatory digital diktat of installing an application raises concerns of invasion of privacy and surveillance of free speech and the right to access information in the Indian digital public sphere. Using critical discourse analysis of the Indian Telecom Cyber Security Rules, 2024, the official news releases from the Indian Press Information Bureau, and the Department of Telecommunications, this paper analyzes how this digital governance infrastructure poses a threat to digital democratic freedom, right to privacy, as well as right to information, and resonates with the logic of the neoliberal surveillance regime. I argue here that the executive intrusion into the citizens’ private lives that undergirds this specific case also resonates with the neofascist tendencies of the present Indian regime. The present regime has unleashed similar surveillance measures that undermine citizens' digital privacy, namely by restricting the use of Virtual Private Networks, which enable users to mask their digital presence. In this paper, I situate the governance of mobile phone use through the “Sanchar Saathi” application within the broader context of governmentality taking shape in India. I frame this paper's discursive-analytical approach within the entanglement of neofascist tendencies, neoliberal governmentality, and the present Indian regime’s efforts to restrict dissent in the digital sphere through surveillance mechanisms.

Digital Transformation I

Jess Brand

Predictive data analytics and the rise of pre-emptive welfare in the UK: Practices from the frontline Across the UK, Local Authorities (LAs) are implementing predictive analytics as a means of governing and ‘overcoming’ complex social challenges like poverty and homelessness (Chamba, 2022). At the same time, these technologies are said to mobilise a pre-emptive logic that reconfigures temporal relations and forecloses alternative futures (Andrejevic, 2019; Amoore, 2013, 2020), often based on speculative, questionable knowledge (Massumi 2015, 2025). Pre-emption can be historicised as a Napoleonic military strategy (Strachan, 2007) that proliferated during the War On Terror (Massumi, 2007) and which shares similar tendencies with algorithmic prediction (Massumi, 2025). On the premise that the welfare state is an under-studied context in this regard, this paper asks why does it matter if pre-emptivity is emerging on the frontline of welfare services through deployments of such technologies? To explore this, I first trace the separate genealogies of prediction and pre-emption in order to consider how they have merged into ‘pre-emptive prediction’ through the spread of data analytics. I suggest that although pre-emption is theorised as a control logic, in social welfare contexts it interplays with enduring principles of care. Whilst Foucauldian approaches to pre-emption are fairly common (e.g. Kaiser 2015; Pellizzoni, 2020) and others find value in a Butler-inspired performativity lens (de Goede et al, 2014), in order to properly account for the ambiguous practice of pre-emptive welfare this paper secondly argues that more analytical value might be found in a Lipsky-inspired (2010) appreciation of ‘street-level bureaucracy’. Finally, using ethnographic insights from two LAs and interviews with frontline workers, I further suggest that control-care tensions are negotiated in highly specific ways in frontline services in order to pre-empt hardship, evictions, and escalating debt. In particular, I highlight ‘pre-emptive care talk’ as the emotional-informational

labour required to translate risk predictions into caring interventions.

Petter Falk

Reconfiguring Vulnerability < the statecraft of/in interoperable welfare systems > Over the past decade, political and administrative initiatives within Swedish public care have advanced data sharing across organizational boundaries as part of broader digital transformation efforts. Systems such as the interoperability compilers SSBTEK, GIF, and the THEA database enable welfare providers to assemble authority-held data to produce digital representations of individuals within the gaze of welfare providers. In short; data combined to new data-driven subjects. In larger public discourse, these systems are presented as examples of interorganizational and intergovernmental cooperation aimed at improving service provision (SKR, 2019; ESV, 2017; European Commission, 2021), thereby reinforcing the notion that data sharing supports welfare practices. At the same time, the political framing of interoperability in welfare administration not only asserts that vulnerability can be addressed through intensified data practices, but also shapes how vulnerability itself is constructed. This follows a recurring pattern. When individuals have multiple contacts with welfare providers—such as health care, social services, and family support—a growing volume of data is produced about them as subjects within the welfare system. The more data that exists, the more data can be shared, and the more extensive the elaboration of a subject's status becomes within an increasingly interoperable welfare landscape. Through new standards and technologies, data can be shared not only within individual welfare sectors but also across technological and epistemological domains (Ribes et al., 2019). As data points are assembled across these domain-independent systems, vulnerable subjects emerge both through negotiations within data infrastructures (Bowker & Star, 2000) and through the reconfiguration of data points into new data-driven entities (Ruppert et al., 2017). Although this technically and epistemologically challenges meny og the conventional logics and rationales of data domains, digitalization discourse continues to position interoperability as a mechanism for safeguarding core public values (Swedish Government Official Reports 2023). Consequently, these data-sharing practices become normalized, facilitating a new form of framing of the vulnerable and governable subject. Addressing this shift, and drawing on ethnographic studies of Swedish public welfare conducted within, the project Digital Vulnerabilities examines interoperability as an understudied dimension of welfare digitalization, and as a process increasingly entangled with datafication, statecraft, and ideas on vulnerabilities. (Abstract with references: https://bit.ly/petterstatecraft)

Krystian Łukasik & Renata Włoch

Title: Asymmetric Futures: Narrating the Digital State within Big Tech Imaginaries Abstract: This paper examines how national digital government strategies are imagined from inside the state in a context where powerful global actors increasingly define what "the digital future" looks like. Drawing on 11 semi-structured interviews with senior officials responsible for drafting Poland's current digitalisation strategies, including the forthcoming Digitalisation Strategy 2035, I reconstruct how policymakers narrate the role of the state, the dynamics of technological change, and the place of digital technologies in public life. Using the concept of narrative repertoires, the analysis identifies three clusters of imaginaries. First, policymakers alternately cast the state as facilitator of innovation, guardian of rights and social cohesion, and technological sovereign seeking to reduce dependence on foreign infrastructures and platforms. Second, they describe technological change as fast, externally driven, and only partially knowable, which justifies modest, incremental forms of anticipatory governance rather than grand, transformative projects. Third, they frame digital technologies simultaneously as strategic opportunities for efficiency and as sources of systemic risk that require legal, ethical, and organisational safeguards. Taken together, these findings characterise contemporary state imaginaries of digital government not as coherent national projects, but as assemblages of constrained agency in an asymmetric imaginative landscape dominated by Big Tech and transnational expert discourses. The paper contributes to debates on digital sovereignty and digital statecraft by showing how public officials in a semi-peripheral EU member state seek to maintain political agency while working with futures largely authored elsewhere. Conceptually and methodologically, it argues for interview-based analysis of narrative repertoires as a way to access the micro-foundations of sociotechnical imaginaries at the moment they begin to take shape.

Nathan Davies

(TITLE) Buying the Future, Inheriting the Past: Anglo-American Contract Regimes for Government Computing. (ABSTRACT) Over the last fifty years, government administrations in the United Kingdom and United States have undergone a profound transformation in how they acquire and govern computational technologies. Computing has become central to public policy and state reform. Procurement has been recast as a strategic site of governance, through which authority, expertise, and responsibility are organised. The supply of government computing has also shifted: prime contractors and systems integrators have given way to new Silicon Valley Firms; bespoke systems have been displaced by scalable platforms; and states increasingly rent, rather than build or own, core digital infrastructures. The latest iteration of this trajectory—most prominently GenAI—is frequently presented as a decisive break with the past, capable of transforming public administration once again. Yet this paper argues that such future-oriented narratives obscures the inheritance of technical systems, contractual relationships, and earlier policy reforms (David, 1985; Hughes, 1994; Dunleavy et al., 2006; Pollitt, 2008). Focusing on the UK and US, the paper draws on archival materials, policy documents and interviews to trace three moments in the evolution of government computing: the rise of middleware and systems integration, the consolidation of commercial cloud computing, and the current turn toward AI. Across these moments, states have engaged with technological change through contract regimes—historically sedimented configurations of procurement rules, supplier markets, organisational capacities, and computing infrastructures. These regimes have become increasingly conjoined through shared suppliers, contractual forms, and technical architectures, producing transnational trajectories that endur across reform cycles. By foregrounding procurement and contracts as critical sites for material and normative contestation, the paper contributes to debates on digital sovereignty, public–private power, and the geopolitics of digital government. It suggests that contemporary concerns about dependence on Big Tech cannot be addressed without reckoning with the historical contract regimes through which states have sought to

“buy the future” of Digital Government. .

Digital Transformation II

Torjus Solheim Eckhoff

Crafting the computerised State –A history of the Norwegian public administration The issue of “digital sovereignty” has grown as a concern in recent political and academic discourses in Norway. Playing with the notion of statecraft, I attend to practices of crafting the State and the computing power (datakraft in Norwegian) underpinning State practices. Rather than looking at current discussions, this paper investigates historical efforts of technological development and political control, by analysing the computerisation (Kling, 1991) of the Norwegian public administration from the 1970s to the 1990s. I follow the modification (Asdal & Hobæk, 2020) of data policy and, through infrastructure inversion (Pelizza, 2016; Star, 1999), the materialisation of a growing information infrastructure underpinning statecraft. How was political control over computing power enacted in public documents and how did a computer infrastructure materialise? Drawing on a practice-oriented document analysis (Asdal & Reinertsen, 2022), the case builds on a curated corpus of public documents published in this period. These include strategy documents and White Papers from politically elected offices, support documents from underlying agencies, and expert enquiries mandated to investigate electronic data processing (EDB). Through these documents, overarching political interests and goals, as well as fined grained material considerations and issues, becomes visible. I observe how the issue of building and ordering computing capacities is shifting alongside perceived needs and political outlooks. The paper draws on research of technological affordance (Hutchby, 2001), the inertia of historical infrastructure as an installed base (Aanestad et al., 2024; Hughes, 1987; Star, 1999) and the wider network of actors comprised of developing and maintaining the infrastructure (Hanseth & Lyytinen, 2010; Kling, 1991). I point to the width of challenges small countries face in navigating national political interest with externally driven technologies, spanning from international alliances to in-house competence asymmetries, findings that can serve as a reflection for the current issues of development.

Karine Côté-Boucher & Mireille Paquet

Title: Legacy Infrastructures and the Mirage of Modernization: the case of Canada’s Global Case Management System Abstract: Amidst scholarship on the deployment of advanced digital technologies (ADT) in governments and critical scholarship on digital migration governance, research often pays little attention to the backbone of such development: government IT systems, infrastructures, and other legacy technological devices. In dialogue with scholarship on digital government, organizational sociology, migration studies, and STS, our analysis focuses on the materiality of state IT infrastructures. Based on a case study of the creation, deployment, and deliquescence of Canada's Global Case Management System (GCMS)—the IT system created in the early 2000s and still used to process all visa and immigration applications—we identify a considerable gap between official state discourses on ADT deployment in Canada's immigration system and the operational realities of implementation using these backbone technologies. Based on interviews with actors who designed GCMS and those who have used it at different points in time, our paper documents the clash between bureaucratic techno-optimism and the technical difficulties that such platforms create for implementers and policymakers. In particular, we highlight three dynamics associated with these legacy devices: (1) the increased stratification of immigration implementation labor between those charged with data entry and those responsible for decisions; (2) the ways in which these infrastructures can limit, instead of enhancing, the possibilities for rapid immigration program changes and reforms; and (3) the ways in which shortcuts developed in the field end up being paraded as high-tech solutions by organizations. Ultimately, we argue that historicizing digital transformation in the public sector—attending to the layered, path-dependent, and often brittle systems underlying contemporary initiatives—is essential for understanding the possibilities and limits of digital statecraft.

Jessamy Perriam

When GDS met DTA: a story of transnational knowledge sharing In 2014, the then Australian Communications Minister Malcolm Turnbull visited the UK to look at the Government Digital Service (GDS) and their approach to digital transformation at a national level. The intention was to emulate the approach taken to British digital transformation and apply it within the Australian context. This paper will trace the attempts by the Australian Government to replicate the British approach to digital transformation in 2015-2016. It will draw upon interviews conducted with both Australian and British staff drafted in to the set up the Digital Transformation Agency according to the GDS blueprint. From a theoretical perspective, it will examine the frictions (Tsing 2005) that occur when attempting to translate an approach from one national context to another, even when they share similar public service and political systems. From a practical perspective, it will present some ‘lessons learned’ from this extreme example of transnational knowledge sharing in public sector digital transformation.

Margarita Boenig-Liptsin

Citizenship and Digitalization in Ukraine in the 1990s and 2020s State sovereignty today is intertwined practically and symbolically with digitalization. But how does sovereignty tied to digitalization configure the social contract linking citizens and the state? To examine this question, I work within the STS idiom of co-production of social and natural order to contrast two historical periods of sovereignty linked to digitalization in Ukraine. The work draws on historical research of public computing in Ukraine and document analysis of activities of the Ukrainian Ministry of Digital Transformation. In the first period of the 1990s, international development experts envisioned that digitalization would support the rule of law and fight government corruption. Foreign and local actors used digitalization to build the country's independence and solidify its young constitution. The second period, from the start of the Russian full-scale invasion to the present, is characterized by the Ukrainian government's strong push to develop digital government functions in response to war. The ‘Diia’ app, by which citizens can interact with different government services, is a key artifact of this effort. With the app, Ukraine not only maintains a largely

functional government-at-a-distance in times of active conflict and territorial threat, but also conveys a national identity of technological prowess and promise to citizens and foreign investors alike. In both periods, I show how digitalization has not only a practical but also an aspirational purpose—to address the country's ailments and bring it into an imagined prosperous sociotechnical future. To do so, social actors integrated digital capacities with the sovereign functions of the state, transforming sovereignty from the inside-out by aiming to bring about a specific form of citizenship. By comparing these two forms of digital citizenship in Ukraine in the 1990s and today, analysts can better appreciate the development of states in advanced technological societies and the meaning of these transformations for democratic life.

Digital Transformation III

Mait Kask, Andra Siibak & Maris Männiste

How Futures Govern Us: Dataism and the Personal State in Estonia AI has become a force through which governments imagine desirable futures and reorganise state citizen relations. Estonia's emerging personal state vision illustrates this shift by presenting a form of welfare and administration that becomes anticipatory, personalised and dependent on automated inference. This paper examines Estonian policy discourse through a combined framework of sociotechnical imaginaries (Jasanoff and Kim 2015), dataism (van Dijck 2014) and critical discourse analysis (Fairclough 2010). Together these approaches highlight how futures are envisioned and how they shape statecraft in the present. The analysis draws on a corpus of Estonian authoritative strategy documents. Across these texts, imaginaries of an anticipatory welfare regime are actively produced. Policy discourse presents a state that predicts life events, intervenes early and optimises administrative processes through integrated data flows (Maffei et al., 2020). Within this vision, dataist assumptions legitimize both the use of data and the anticipation of citizens' needs. These developments are framed as necessary foundations for national progress rather than as political decisions. These futures coexist with dependencies on global cloud providers and private-sector infrastructures, creating tensions between aspirations for nationally grounded digital capability and the platform-based dependencies highlighted in recent work on digital government and strategic reliance (Van Dijck, Poell, & De Waal, 2018). Such contradictions reveal how futures govern through the promises they articulate and through the silences they create around discretion, inequality, labour and infrastructural vulnerability. The paper argues that Estonia's personal state functions as a form of anticipatory statecraft that reorganises welfare through datafication while positioning Estonia as a model of digital modernity. This analytical framework provides the foundation for forthcoming empirical research with civil servants and information managers who translate these imagined futures into everyday administrative practice and negotiate or resist their implications.

Sruthi Vanguri

Title: Reconstructing Statecraft through the Imaginaries and Diffusion of DPI Systems Abstract: Digital Public Infrastructures (DPIs), comprising interoperable digital identity, payments, and data-exchange systems, have rapidly emerged as globally circulating templates for organising state-citizen interactions in the past few years. Popularised during India's 2023 G20 Presidency and promoted by multilateral institutions and philanthropic networks, DPIs are now being exported, adapted, and institutionalised across diverse political and administrative contexts. Yet despite their expanding geopolitical significance, academic scholarship on DPIs remains limited, with most analyses produced by policy actors rather than critical social science. This paper responds to this gap by examining how DPIs are visualised, framed, and transferred as models of public governance across countries. The study begins with the DPI Map developed by the Institute for Innovation and Public Purpose (IIPP) at University College London, treating it not merely as a dataset but as a visual artefact that constructs a global field of DPIs. The map is analysed as a site where sociotechnical imaginaries of scalable, interoperable, and "governance-ready" infrastructures are produced and made globally legible. Building from this starting point, the paper investigates how these imaginaries travel transnationally and how networks of actors, including multilateral institutions, technical experts, consulting groups, and state agencies, actively promote the diffusion of DPI systems. Methodologically, the paper combines: (1) policy analysis of multi-actor systems, tracing institutional collaborations, MoUs, and advisory engagements that facilitate DPI transfer; and (2) interpretive content analysis of policy documents, strategy papers, and regulatory frameworks that construct DPIs as desirable governance templates. A comparative focus on India Stack and the emerging Euro Stack illustrates how different configurations of DPI-enabled statecraft take shape: one grounded in financial inclusion and development-oriented digitalisation, the other oriented toward digital sovereignty and regulatory harmonisation. The paper ultimately argues that DPIs function as both material infrastructures and circulating governance models, reshaping state capacities and geopolitical alignments in the contemporary digital order.

Carina R. Nasser & Mattéo Bard

Fear of the Inside, Fear of the Outside: Building Sovereignty Through Digital IDs in Brazil and the EU - This paper offers a comparative analysis of how digital identification infrastructures are used for and give shape to digital sovereignty in two contrasting political contexts: Brazil, a large federal state focused on internal governance challenges; and the European Union, a supranational union responding to external pressures while lacking traditional statehood. Analyzing policy documents and institutional communications, this study will identify differences and similarities in how each context frames digital identification as a solution to perceived losses of—or long-term struggles for—control. In Brazil, the integration of biometrics into the country's new digital ID infrastructure, the cédula de identidade nacional, is framed as a matter of curbing internal threats of tax and welfare fraud. Therefore, biometric-inclusive digital identification addresses longstanding concerns within Brazilian statecraft: keeping track of all Brazilian residents, establishing a trustworthy welfare state, and guaranteeing the internal security of the Brazilian state and its citizens. In the EU, the interoperability initiative integrates several migration and policing databases into a unified architecture managed by eu-LISA through digital identification infrastructures. The initiative is justified as a response

to external threats driven by the migration crisis. Although the EU is not a state, the reliance of member states on this shared infrastructure effectively consolidates EU-level authority over cross-border mobility in the name of greater internal security. Our comparative design reveals how digital identification technologies mediate different sovereignty claims depending on political structure and threat perception. However, it also shows interregional continuities in how these technologies play a role in building sovereignty through security concerns. By pairing a sovereign state with a supranational entity, we demonstrate how digital identification infrastructures are not just tools to modernise governance: They actively redistribute power within and across countries. Our analysis contributes to debates on digital sovereignty, digital statecraft, and the geopolitics of public-sector digital transformations.

Alexei Tsinovoi & Ask Greve

"Rocks in flux: monuments to Danish digitalization." International delegations that come to learn about Danish digitalization are typically taken to Digital Hub Denmark – an ‘award-winning 750 m² visitor centre [...] showcasing Denmark's digital journey’ (Digital Hub Denmark n.d.). Designed to help ‘brand Denmark’ and ‘connect international stakeholders with opportunities to collaborate with, procure from, or support Danish GovTech’ (Digital Hub Denmark n.d.), the space is located in a historical sugar factory and blend ‘Nordic values’ with ‘contemporary elements’ that aim to perform Denmark’s leadership in the field. Beside generic Danish design elements and several interactive installations, the space is dominated by what can be described as a monument to Danish digitalization: three boulders that present a timeline of ‘Denmark’s digital journey’. In the literature, monuments are typically associated with national identity and temporality. As Neumann (2018) explains, ‘[m]onuments try to halt time by narrating it in a material that is intended to last’, thus articulating and projecting Self/Other relations. The boulders can accordingly be seen as part of Danish nation branding efforts to project the country internationally as a global leader in public sector digitalization, articulating Denmark’s ‘soft power’ (Nye 2008). In this paper, we examine the ephemeral nature of digitalization efforts as nation branding exercises by considering how this history is brought into the present through the Digital Hub exhibition space and historical antecedents of nation branding in Denmark. We regard these efforts as performative, enacting an opportune economy for foreign investment and trade while simultaneously signposting a policy field of national importance. At the same time, we suggest that the impermanence of IT systems and global rankings of ‘digital competitiveness’ may unwittingly be attenuated through these historical juxtapositions, not least at a time when efforts toward digital leadership are problematized by emerging concerns around digital vulnerability, sovereignty, and growing awareness of international interdependencies.

Digital Sovereignty in Theory & Practice I

Janine Patricia Santos

The Paradox of Digital Sovereignty: unpacking ‘digital sovereignty’ and the ‘public’ in Digital Public Infrastructure developments in EU and Togo Digital Public Infrastructures (DPIs) have become a newfound strategic obsession in digital infrastructure development across the globe. DPIs strategies are closely anchored on claims to ‘digital sovereignty’ (Adler-Nissen & Eggeling 2024), as digital infrastructures become geopolitical terrains marked by the increasing global dependency on US and China-based Big Tech. This paper serves as an exploration on the ‘discursive politics’ (Falkner, et al. 2024) of concepts such as ‘digital sovereignty’ and the ‘public’, upon which sociotechnical imaginaries of DPIs are anchored. Through a critical juxtaposition (Udupa & Dattatreyan 2023) of DPI strategies in the EU and Togo, I argue that DPIs are complex systems embedded in the material conditions within which they are developed, containing inherent contradictions that animate its processes and that results to the paradox of ‘digital sovereignty’ being negotiated at various scales. I view ‘digital sovereignty’ as a multi-scalar concept and discursive practice that reconstitutes the ‘public’ in the process of its reclaiming, as citizens, states and Big Tech attempt to regain ownership and control of data, discourse and digital lives.

Sandeep Mertia

Derivative Sovereignty: Rethinking the State in/of Global Techno-Capitalism. This paper theorizes derivative sovereignty as a way to understand how postcolonial and global South states pursue digital autonomy while remaining structurally entangled in the architectures and political economies of global techno-capitalism. Drawing on India’s Digital Public Infrastructures (DPIs) and emerging “sovereign AI” stacks, the paper argues that contemporary digital government must be approached as a mode of statecraft in which the state and techno-capitalism actively reconstitute one another through layered dependencies, speculative design, and shifting configurations of authority. DPIs and AI stacks promise national control over identity, payments, data flows, and language models, positioning the state as a platform capable of orchestrating welfare, markets, and innovation. Yet these sovereign aspirations are enacted through infrastructures reliant on transnational compute, globally standardized API frameworks, benchmarking regimes, pretrained models, and corporate laboratories. Sovereignty becomes derivative—asserted through architectures the state neither fully owns nor governs but must strategically inhabit. This derivative condition is not merely a limitation; it is constitutive of how contemporary state formations emerge through their recursive entanglement with platformization and data-driven value production. In a world where dominant AI models are trained on datasets that are more than 90 percent English, the pursuit of sovereignty by multilingual and postcolonial states raises urgent global questions: what forms of political and epistemic autonomy are possible when the foundational infrastructures of intelligence reproduce such profound linguistic asymmetries? India’s efforts to computationally standardize socio-linguistic diversity, integrate welfare and financial governance through identity-linked platforms, and develop nationally branded language models reveal a state increasingly imagined as a stack: modular, interoperable, and perpetually unfinished. These architectures recast political representation, redefine citizen legibility, and bind statecraft to the logics and aspirations of platform capitalism. By situating these developments within longer trajectories of postcolonial planning, linguistic politics, and neoliberal restructuring, the paper offers derivative sovereignty as a conceptual framework for rethinking the state in/of global techno-capitalism.

Frederik Schade

From Digital Sovereignty to Technopolitics: Reorienting Research and Policy Abstract As digital sovereignty discourse gains prominence in international geopolitics, scholars struggle with its significant ambiguity. To aid theorization and policy, this paper aims to clarify the political rationality of digital sovereignty. At a first glance, a Foucauldian perspective seems to confirm its political ambiguity, as policy in this domain mobilizes techniques attributable not merely to political sovereignty but also to discipline and biopolitical security. However, as we show, a unifying tendency can be identified across international discourses on digital sovereignty whereby the technological consistently replaces the human as the primary problem and object of politics. Based on this observation and drawing on examples from US, Chinese, and European policymaking, we trace the particular technopolitical rationality underlying current digital sovereignty agendas. While selectively drawing on techniques of sovereignty, discipline, and biopolitical security, we argue that this emergent rationality signals a novel and under-researched convergence in international politics towards a techno-centric political orientation. Its rationality responds to the political problem(s) posed by so-called general-purpose technologies (GPTs) based on their perceived foundational, enabling, and constraining capabilities. To govern these, it focuses its energies upon creating and sustaining technological ecosystems as its primary object(s) of intervention. The specific rationality of this orientation, then, aims at strategically enabling and harnessing widespread techno-social transformation(s) while avoiding undesirable technical constraints through strategic ecosystem interventions. Such interventions express a general technique of technological planning actualized through instances of industrial, economic, educational, and immigration policy initiatives and reform. Ultimately, this theory of technopolitical rationality, we argue, equips us with a novel conceptual vocabulary to think through the politics of digital sovereignty across both research and policy.

Ida Marie Iversen & Maja Hvarregaard Pedersen

In recent years, digital sovereignty has become a central concern in debates about digital government and statecraft, particularly as public infrastructures increasingly rely on global technology providers and transnational networks. This paper contributes to these discussions by examining how digital sovereignty is enacted, negotiated, and experienced through infrastructural arrangements in Greenland – a context where digital government depends on a small number of fragile and geopolitically significant communication systems. Drawing on ethnographic fieldwork conducted across multiple sites in Greenland, including hospitals, cable landing stations, control rooms, harbors, and airports in both cities and settlements, we examine how submarine cables, radio chains, and satellite connections function as the arteries of Greenlandic digital government. These infrastructures sustain public services such as healthcare, administration, and mobility, while simultaneously exposing forms of dependency on external actors, technical systems, and geopolitical relations. When these infrastructural arteries falter or are perceived as vulnerable, questions of sovereignty, autonomy, and resilience surface in everyday practices and institutional decision-making. Methodologically, the paper reflects on how existing approaches to studying infrastructure, ranging from STS scholars to more sovereignty-focused frameworks, perform when confronted with Arctic infrastructural conditions. Rather than treating digital sovereignty as a predefined policy objective, our analysis shows how it emerges empirically through infrastructural encounters involving technicians, health workers, public institutions, and global technology providers. In doing so, the paper situates Greenland's digital infrastructure within broader debates about digital government, public–private dependency, and geopolitical vulnerability, offering methodological reflections relevant to scholars of STS, digital government, and contemporary statecraft.

Samuele Fratini

The Sociotechnical Politics of Digital Sovereignty: Frictional Infrastructures and the Alignment of Privacy and Geopolitics In an era of geopolitical tensions, digital sovereignty is crucial for states seeking autonomy in the digital realm. This paper examines how digital sovereignty is achieved not just through state mandates but also through the alignment of infrastructures, institutions, and cultures. Using Science and Technology Studies, it conceptualize digital sovereignty as a hybrid black box: a provisional assemblage of technical, legal, and cultural components. Through a case study of Threema, a Swiss privacy-focused messaging app, I analyze how non-state actors co-produce digital sovereignty with public institutions. Using interviews and document analysis, I identify three frictional dynamics (privacy, seclusion, and territorialism) that destabilize the hybrid black box, revealing how sovereignty is negotiated amid competing forces. My analysis shows how Threema's privacy-centric design and alignment with Swiss frameworks have made it a key tool for Swiss institutions, reducing foreign tech dependencies and aligning with European digital sovereignty efforts. By embedding territorialism into its architecture, Threema exemplifies how non-state actors can perform sovereign functions, although it was not born with this purpose. This study contributes to debates on digital sovereignty by showing how non-state actors enact infrastructural practices that serve state interests. It highlights how local innovations can align with regional efforts to reduce reliance on Big Tech and assert digital autonomy. Moreover, Threema demonstrates that, although digital sovereignty emerges as a geopolitical imperative, it can be pursued ethically through privacy-focused technologies, enhancing democratic governance by fostering transparency and citizen trust. Key themes include using privacy and territorialism to resist surveillance, the role of local innovations in digital autonomy, and potential European collaboration on tech alternatives. I argue that digital sovereignty is a sociotechnical achievement requiring alignment of diverse actors and infrastructures.

Digital Sovereignty in Theory & Practice II

Joao C. Magalhaes & Edemilson Parana

The political ambiguities of digital sovereignty: Insights from Brazil -- The emergence of GenAI and the alliance between Donald Trump and Big Tech have not only accelerated long-standing concerns about digital sovereignty but also exposed an apparent conundrum around this topic. If infrastructural autonomy is so paramount, why do governments not act decisively to break up their dependence on US companies?

This paper explores the case of Brazil to argue that answering this question demands attending to political factors that go beyond technological development, investment capacity, or sociotechnical path-dependencies. Underlying the seeming obviousness of digital sovereignty are complex sets of views and interests of multiple local actors – creating ambiguities that have, at least in the Brazilian case, hampered this policy agenda. Our argument builds on the analysis of three key moments. In 2013, responding to the news that then-President Dilma Rousseff was spied on by the NSA, Congress passed the Marco Civil da Internet – a law that ironically established both privacy guarantees to users and legal immunities to platforms, further entrenching their dominance. The second moment occurred during the presidency of Jair Bolsonaro, who acted to protect platforms from content liability and eagerly negotiated the rollout of Elon Musk's Starlink in the Amazon rainforest but embraced Brazil's independent Central Bank's creation of PIX (a free and publicly managed digital payment system). Third, the return of Lula da Silva to power in 2022 marked an intensification of criticisms of Big Tech's power, disinformation, and their association with Bolsonaro and the far-right – from both him and the Supreme Court, which temporarily banned X in 2024 and recently diluted Marco Civil's immunities. At the same time, his government has strongly pursued data center investments from Big Tech and is unwilling to prioritize new anti-Big Tech policy. Our analysis suggests that the exact meaning of digital sovereignty is in constant flux and dispute. Multiple political groups and governmental bodies have different (and often competing) ideological, electoral, and economic incentives to seek, avert, and politicise this theme, at varying intensities and moments. In making this argument, we hope to show that the realisation of technological autonomy cannot escape the highly contextual bundle of non-technical complexities that shape its framing and trajectory.

Marguerite Borelli

Working title: "Content moderation as a privileged vantage point for the study of digital sovereignty: a case study on the governance of terrorist content". Research on platform governance and digital sovereignty has largely developed as separate fields that acknowledge but rarely meaningfully engage with one another, apart from a few notable exceptions (Kachelmann & Reiners, 2023; Flonk et al., 2024). In the context of the global 'techlash', however, certain content categories have been securitized. Their governance thus raises clear issues of sovereignty, as security matters are traditionally considered 'high politics'. This is the case of disinformation, particularly as it relates to foreign interference (Kachelmann & Reiners, 2023), as well as for the category of "terrorist and violent extremist content" (TVEC), (Ahmed, 2023; Borelli, 2021; 2025). In a context where states disagree on what constitutes "terrorism" or "extremism", and even more so on the actors to whom these labels apply, the governance of TVEC on major, quasi-global platforms brings the following sovereignty-relevant questions to the fore: whose terrorism designations are implemented on mainstream social media, and how? And what tools do states possess to ensure platform compliance? This paper contributes to bridging the gap between platform governance and digital sovereignty literatures, by drawing on the TVEC moderation case study as a particularly revealing site of (inter)dependencies between actors, and thus, a privileged vantage point from which to observe their "digital sovereignty" strategies. The analysis draws on an empirical investigation into the governance of TVEC by Meta (Facebook, Instagram), Google (YouTube) and Twitter (now X) and the public-private relations it generates, combining stakeholder interviews (n=31) with grey literature. While public authorities often justify content regulation by invoking the enforcement of national laws online (Gorwa, 2024), the practice of content moderation (Grimmelmann, 2015; Gillespie, 2018) involves hybrid forms of agency that are distributed geographically and across the public–private divide. Mapping this process to identify key "control points" (Loveluck, 2025) sheds light on some of the power relations that structure the contemporary digital public sphere – not only between states and major platforms but also among states themselves (eg. EU-US relations), among companies, and between large platforms and their subcontractors who carry out moderation work.

Roger Burrows & Nicholas Gane

The Sovereign Individual, Reloaded; Surfacing Peter Thiel's Alt-Canon:This paper reconstructs the ideological formation that underpins Peter Thiel's politics of exit, exemption and privately engineered sovereignty. It argues that Thiel's investments, writings and alliances are held together by an 'alt-canon' that reaches well beyond familiar libertarian and neoliberal reference points. Drawing on René Girard, Leo Strauss, Oswald Spengler, Carl Schmitt and James Dale Davidson and William Rees-Mogg's The Sovereign Individual, this canon reworks ideas of mimetic rivalry, natural hierarchy, civilisational decline, sovereign exception and digital 'megapolitics' into a coherent, post-(neo)liberal political economy. The paper traces how this repertoire is condensed and popularised in Thiel's own interventions, from Zero to One and The Straussian Moment to his 2020 preface to The Sovereign Individual and recent eschatological lectures on apocalypse, the Antichrist and the katechon. Across these sites, we show how monopoly, jurisdictional arbitrage, cryptography and experimental forms of governance are framed as means to relocate sovereignty into privately controlled domains, often in explicit tension with mass democracy. Linking this doctrinal infrastructure to concrete projects – payments systems, data platforms, charter-city schemes, crypto networks and offshored compounds – the paper argues that what is promoted as entrepreneurial innovation is also a programme for unbundling state functions and respecifying citizenship as a portfolio of exits and bespoke protections. Thiel's eschatological turn intensifies rather than softens this vision, casting elite technologists as custodians of civilisational survival licensed to act beyond conventional democratic constraint. We conclude that this alt-canon sits outside the liberal tradition and tends towards authoritarian, at points fascistic, configurations in which rule-by-exception is normalised at the infrastructural level, public law is displaced by private ordering and political authority is redistributed to a narrow, computationally empowered elite.

Digital Sovereignty: Alternatives & Lock-ins I

Roser Pujads & Daniel Curto-Millet

"Performing digital sovereignty: The case of AI in Europe" The global race to lead in AI development, dominated by US and Chinese firms, has intensified debates over digital sovereignty in Europe (Bosoer & Innerarity, 2025; Bria, 2023; Yew et al., 2025). As US-based AI infrastructures increasingly underpin critical data, cloud, and compute systems across the region (Rikap & Lundvall, 2021; Srnicek, 2026), European policymakers and industry actors have begun to frame sovereign AI development as essential to securing technological autonomy, economic competitiveness, and democratic self-determination. Yet digital sovereignty remains a contested concept with competing visions of what should be sovereign, who should exercise control, and in whose interest (Bellanova et al., 2022; Pohle, 2020; Pohle et al., 2024). Using a mixed qualitative approach combining discourse analysis and technography (Kien, 2009; van der Vlist et al., 2024), this paper analyses how such visions are materially and discursively constructed in the case of Mistral AI, a French generative AI start-up widely positioned as a flagship example of "European AI sovereignty." Our analysis shows that while Mistral AI symbolically embodies European ambitions for sovereign AI, its development is deeply entangled with global infrastructures and venture capital logics that complicate claims to autonomy (Fratini, 2025). We argue that digital sovereignty should be understood not as a fixed regulatory endpoint or institutional arrangement, but as a contested and discursively grounded sociotechnical formation shaped by conflicting economic, political, legal, and infrastructural forces. Furthermore, we suggest that the interpretative malleability of the concept of sovereignty thrives on contradictory meanings in order to extend potential alliances and advance the company's agenda by adapting its discourse on sovereignty to fit with changing external events.

Lasse Uhrskov Kristensen

Open-source, international collaboration, digital transformation

Emilie Mørch Groth

Framing open source as an alternative to Big Tech in public institutions - The interest for open source in public sectors is growing alongside the concerns related to digital sovereignty. Policy debates increasingly frame open-source software as a strategic counterweight to Big Tech, as the open-source approach is intended to strengthen digital autonomy and reduce technological dependency. Yet the discourse surrounding digital sovereignty is heterogeneous, related to both territorial and post-territorial sovereignty in domains of security, economy, and rights (Adler-Nissen and Eggeling, 2024), and it's invoked to justify a plethora of aims: ensuring national security, democratic values, and rights, limiting vulnerabilities and vendor-lock ins, enabling actual free choices in technology uptake and usage, and positioning EU within the "AI race" (France 24, 2025; Moreau, 2025; Mortensen and Nielsen, 2025; Olifent, 2025). This presentation therefore seeks to elicit, how open source plays into notions of digital sovereignty by exploring: How is open source framed as alternative infrastructure in public institutions in terms of dependency, organisation, and regulation? This question will be examined through an empirical case: a project named OS2skole, where municipal actors seek to construct an open source-based platform as an alternative to Big Tech in public schools (OS2, no date). The analysis draws on Science and Technology Studies (STS), and the case will be explored with offset in Actor-Network theory (ANT) (Latour, 2005), which will allow a mapping of the organisation of involved actors, and an exploration of how open source is framed in terms of digital sovereignty. The case will be unfolded qualitatively by engaging with project documents (e.g. project plans and communication strategies) and project stakeholders (e.g. interviews and meeting observations). By providing empirical insights into an emerging open-source platform in the public sector, this presentation aims to contribute to debates on digital sovereignty and Big Tech alternatives.

Gianmarco Cristofari

Public Stacks and Sovereign Clouds? The Making of 'Functional' Digital Sovereignty in Latin America By Gianmarco Cristofari In this paper, I examine how Latin American states are experimenting with "public stacks" and quasi□sovereign clouds as they navigate geopolitically fraught digital infrastructures. While the European Union has come to exemplify a regulatory response to digital sovereignty—often framed through the "Brussels effect" of extraterritorial rule□setting (Bradford, 2020)—I trace how, in Latin America, sovereign capacities are being made functionally: through payment rails, identity systems, and state□owned networks, rather than primarily via comprehensive regulatory packages. Methodologically, I draw on ongoing fieldwork in Brazil, Colombia, Argentina, and Uruguay. The analysis is based on more than forty semi□structured interviews that I conducted with academics, social movements, and public servants in state□owned companies and regulatory agencies. I develop three case studies of public digital infrastructure (Almeida & Martins, 2025; Eaves et al., 2025), designed, at least in part, to underpin digital sovereignty: (1) the Brazilian instant payment system PIX and national identification and registry systems, deployed as critical components of monetary and data infrastructures (Amboage et al., 2024; Schapiro et al., 2023); (2) Brazil's Cadastro Ambiental Rural (CAR), where environmental and land□use data become a way to let farmers gain access to governmental programs and simplify bureaucratic tasks (Beneventi & Oliveira, 2025; Henkes, 2025); and (3) Uruguay's state□owned telecommunications company Antel and its role in providing connectivity, cloud capacity, and data□centre infrastructure as a "national backbone." On the basis of these cases, I theorise "functional digital sovereignty" as a situated, piecemeal, and contested practice, enacted through specific infrastructural functions. Notwithstanding contemporary debates on digital sovereignty "as a service," which reveal how difficult it is for states to be fully independent from companies such as AWS (Grohmann & Costa Barbosa, 2025), I show that the Latin American experience illustrates how regulatory measures must be complemented by creative forms of industrial and infrastructural policy capable of shaping, owning, and operating the underlying technical systems on which public services increasingly depend.

Digital Sovereignty: Alternatives & Lock-ins II

Matilde Bro, Rebecca Adler-Nissen & Kristin Anabel Eggeling

Title: Sovereignty by design: AI gigafactories, public-private partnerships and Europe’s infrastructural ‘turn’ Abstract: Sovereignty by design: AI gigafactories, public-private partnerships and Europe’s infrastructural ‘turn’ Matilde Bro, PhD-student, University of Copenhagen, Department of Political Science mbha@ifs.ku.dk This article examines how digital sovereignty in the European Union (EU) is designed and co-produced by EU institutions, (member) states and private consortia’s through public private partnerships. Through a case study of the EU Commissions launch of the so-called AI gigafactories, a public-private partnerships initiated to establish supercomputing ecosystems across five of EU’s member states to store data, attract talent and develop advanced (European) AI models, I contribute with new insights to how the processes, relations and practices of building AI infrastructure design and co-produce digital sovereignty in Europe. Designing such a European alternative to American digital infrastructure, which European citizens, companies and governments are deeply dependent on embodies Europe’s infrastructural ‘turn’, positioning digital infrastructure as a geopolitical asset and a site of contestation between private and public actors over who should own and operate it. Drawing on Science & Technology studies (STS) and International Relations’ (IR) infrastructural ‘turn’, I conceptualize these AI gigafactories as public private partnerships of (geo)political infrastructures that (re)order space, authority and identity. I argue that EU’s AI gigafactories operate on two levels: material – embodying sovereignty in physical supercomputing capacity, certifications and standards; and narrative – seeking security-of-self for Europe as a technological actor amid global dependencies. Through these levels, I identity three sovereignty dilemmas of control, territorialization and membership. Empirically, the article draws on ethnographic fieldwork in Brussels, combining participant observation, semi-structured interviews with EU’s digital policymakers and industry actors as well as document analysis of official material (policy paper, statements, speeches) released by EU institutions, (member) states and companies between 2023 and 2025. The multi-sited approach reveals how infrastructural governance becomes a site of identity-making and geopolitical positioning contributing to the literature on sovereignty, security and sociotechnical imaginaries.

Dr Paloma Viejo Otero & Dr Eugenia Siapera

While debates on European digital sovereignty predominantly focus on state-level alternatives, a crucial question remains unaddressed: what grassroots infrastructures have already resisted Big Tech enclosure, and what can they teach us about building resilient digital sovereignties? Under the dominance of platform capitalism, both scholarship and policy often seek catharsis through top-down transformation, overlooking existing alternatives. This project responds to a challenge posed by an Occupy activist at the 2024 AoIR conference: "The ongoing mistake lies in seeking catharsis instead of asking: What is already working? How do we organize around it?" We examine community-based media infrastructures that have persisted despite Big Tech's pressures, asking: Do networks demonstrating strong cosmological and organizational continuities show greater resilience against platform capitalism, and can this resilience inform European digital sovereignty strategies? Theoretically, we innovate with the concept of Media Persistence—defined as the sustained organizational, technical, and ideological continuities that alternative media initiatives maintain across temporal ruptures and spatial contexts. We trace this persistence in four community and mesh networks: Guifi.net (Catalonia), Freifunk (Berlin), Nodo50 (Madrid), and B4RN (Ireland). These cases offer critical variation; while the first three have operated since the 1990s, B4RN's recent founding (2020) tests whether alternative imaginaries and organizing knowledge survived platform consolidation. Using a 2×4 analytical framework, we examine cosmological and organizational dimensions across these four networks. Through archival material, website analysis, and in-depth interviews, we trace their continuities with particular attention to the 2015-2025 rupture, when platform dominance intensified. By documenting these sustained socio-technical imaginaries, we provide evidence-based models for digital sovereignty that move beyond Big Tech dependency. By documenting these sustained material practices and their socio-technical imaginaries, we provide evidence-based models for digital sovereignty that move beyond Big Tech dependency, warranting popular recognition, public investment, and directly informing European digital statecraft beyond commercial partnerships.

Matt Spencer

Securing by principle: Cyber assurance instruments for digital government To be used in public services, and in regulated sectors of the economy, digital technologies must pass a number of different evaluative tests. They must satisfy functional requirements. They must represent ‘value for money’. They also must be secure. In this paper I argue that we should understand digital government through its instruments, and that the ‘principle’ is an increasingly important tool of (digital) government (Lascoumes and Le Galès, 2007, Hood, 1983). To this end, I offer an analysis of the history and policy narratives associated with the ‘principles based’ approach to product security assurance in the UK developed over the past 5 years. To explain the rise of principles, I examine the challenges of valuing security and the fate of previous assurance schemes (Spencer, 2025, Spencer, 2022). I look at the influence of cloud computing, and the enablement of its adoption for digital government in the 2010s via the UK ‘cloud security principles’. I also unpack the influence of ‘goal-based assurance’ in safety as a model for security (Broadribb, 2015). Referring to goals and outcomes over standard control sets, principles are imagined to afford a distinctive, more flexible kind of control over design processes, procurement, markets, and infrastructures. Recent work bringing evaluation studies to bear on the role of principles in ethical design has pointed to the tensions they create between action and value (Moats and Trifuljesko, 2025). I extend this line of analysis, arguing that in the security context these tensions are recognised to present a challenge for implementation, but that they are also the source of the instrument’s virtues, offering the prospect of better locating responsibilities among vendors, evaluators and customers. BROADRIBB, M. P. 2015. What have we really learned? Twenty five years after Piper Alpha. Process Safety Progress, 34, 16-23. HOOD, C. C. 1983. The tools of government, London, Macmillan. LASCOUMES, P. & LE GALèS, P. 2007. Introduction: Understanding public policy through its instruments—From the nature of instruments to the sociology of public policy instrumentation. Governance, 20, 1-21. MOATS, D. & TRIFULJESKO, S. 2025. Valuable actions and actionable values: Tinkering with principles and practices in AI ethics. The Sociological Review, 00380261251316661. SPENCER, M. 2022. Characterising assurance: scepticism and mistrust in cyber security. Journal of Cultural Economy, 1-16. SPENCER, M. The embeddedness of security: theorising quality uncertainty in markets for secure software. New Security Paradigms Workshop, 2025. ACM.

Gro Stueland Skorpen

Abstract Claiming the cloud? Norway's digital nation-work in a new moment for the geopolitics of data Gro Stueland Skorpen _____ This paper studies Norway's first tentative moves to nationalize cloud storage of data, reading these efforts as a claim for digital sovereignty for Norway. Empirically, it is based on ethnographic fieldwork in the National Audit Office (NAO) of Norway at a time when discussions on moving the data used in audit to the servers of a commercial cloud provider were taking place. It follows this talk to a broader public conversation about cloud storage of the state's data, tracing its tensions back to divergent views on what data are: While data science views data as means of production, this is at odds with the data as ends view, predominant for instance in legalistic EU discourse on privacy. The case of a National Cloud for Norway troubles what is on the inside and on the outside of the state: Big Tech clearly contributes cloud capacity and technology in the inside of states such as Norway, and yet, these companies also represent an outside, even a threat, to the state. This paper seeks to provide a mapping of this new geopolitics of data as it presents for Norway, a country that due to its geographical location on the Scandinavian peninsula is faced not only with American tech dominance, but also Russian hybrid aggression against digital infrastructure. Its multi-scalar analysis of data politics from the "small" bureaucratic practices in the NAO to the grand declarations of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs suggests a deep disagreement within the digital state of Norway about what the premises of digital sovereignty should be. How the state will try to resolve these tensions, the paper argues, will depend crucially on whether the data science view of data as a means or the securitized version of data as ends wins forth. Keywords: digital sovereignty – geopolitics of data – cloud – data storage – data politics

Digital Sovereignty: Alternatives & Lock-ins III

Oscar Arruda d'Alva, Rodrigo Santaella-Gonçalves & Edemilson Paraná

From statecraft to platform power: the travails of statistical sovereignty Oscar d'Alva, Rodrigo Santaella-Gonçalves This paper examines the contested terrain of statistical sovereignty through a comparative analysis of Europe and Brazil—two critical sites where state and corporate forces converge to reshape official statistics in the digital age. While national statistical systems have historically served as core infrastructures of governance and citizenship, the growing relevance of big data, cloud computing, and AI-driven analytics increasingly challenges their autonomy and legitimacy. We define statistical sovereignty as the democratic capacity to socially control the production, dissemination, and interpretation of public statistics, and show how it is being undermined by Big Tech's enclosure of data, platform logics of commodification, and supranational governance frameworks. Drawing on a dual empirical perspective from the Global North and South, we argue that official statistics are not merely technical instruments but are inherently shaped by political contention over who defines legitimate knowledge about society, more specifically, who controls the structures, norms, and practices of statistical production. The European case reveals a recent movement to protect official statistics against the power of corporate platforms. This effort materializes in new data regulations and political interventions by the European Statistical System, which seeks mandatory access to privately held data alongside the development of a regional statistical cloud. Brazil's experience alternatively illustrates both the fragility and resilience of Global South statistical institutions under datafication pressures: austerity has weakened their technical capacity, while initiatives supported by Big Tech exert growing influence, even as actors within the statistical field mobilize professional ethos, legal reforms, and sovereignty discourses to defend public control over data infrastructures. By highlighting the epistemic and material tensions that emerge when state-produced numbers intersect with platform power, this paper contributes to rethinking information, cognitive, and symbolic authority in datafied societies.

Eva Iris Otto, Sofie Flensburg & Signe Sophus Lai

The power of dependency: Open-Source Software as the solution to digital Sovereignty Recent geopolitical tensions have elevated digital sovereignty to a topic of significant political interest in Europe. A central concern in these debates is the growing digital dependency on U.S. Big Tech companies, particularly through the integration of American platform solutions into state infrastructures. In response, open-source software has re-emerged from its politically dormant state in several places, including in the Danish national context. Framed as an antidote to U.S. and Big Tech dependence, open-source solutions are imagined to promise local sovereignty and empowerment, an idea championed by both long-standing and new proponents across state and open-source contexts. However, examining the software underpinning open-source solutions reveals a relationship fundamentally constituted by dependence. This raises the question of how dependence is being imagined and constructed in political debates, while at the same time also being socio-materially constructed and reconfigured within software infrastructures. What is a dependence, for whom, and how are these made to matter within digital state infrastructures? This paper explores the paradox of dependence as a socio-technical relation, by focusing on open source solutions within digital state infrastructures. It does so by ethnographically and netnographically mapping the debates and current and emerging open source software solutions and their infrastructural dependencies mobilized within Danish municipal and state systems as purported solutions to the challenge of local digital sovereignty. Drawing on a conceptual background from digital materialities, platform studies, and anthropology, the paper thereby examines the role of dependence and its relation to how we might conceptualize power in digital (state) infrastructures.

Damiano Razzoli & Nicola Casucci

Digital Sovereignty as Inhabitation: Civic Statecraft and Proximity-Based Public Digital Spaces The contemporary crisis of digital platforms reveals a fundamental tension: when platform rules diverge from democratic principles, exclusion follows. X blocking the European Commission's advertising account following an EU fine exemplifies how commercial platforms enforce uninhabitability when values misalign. This paper reframes digital sovereignty not merely as geopolitical competition, but as the capacity to inhabit digital spaces as full citizens rather than extracted users. Reclaiming this capacity requires forms of civic digital statecraft: the strategic design and governance of digital

infrastructures for the public good. Drawing on Floridi's (2020) tripartite framework articulating supranational, national, and popular sovereignty, focusing on popular sovereignty exercised by proximate communities. Alongside critical analyses of state-platform entanglements (Heidebrecht 2024; Papaevangelou & Siapera 2025; Wang & Gray 2022), we engage with van Dijck et al.'s (2019) shift from consumer welfare to citizen wellbeing: since users are simultaneously consumers, producers, and citizens whose democratic duties depend on platform services, platform governance must address broader public values – democratic control, fair labour practices, accountability – beyond economic metrics (van Dijck 2020). Against extractive platform logic – enshittification and algorithmic control – we propose spatial reclamation: digital platforms reimagined as navigable public spaces for democratic encounter. This argument unfolds through analysing the Hamlet project (Reggio Emilia, Italy): a civic digital platform structured as public space addressing neighbourhood needs through community-driven governance. We analyse Hamlet as local digital statecraft, demonstrating how public digital infrastructure can extend physical public life, strengthen social bonds, and enable onlife citizenship (Floridi 2015). The case reveals how popular sovereignty operates through designing alternatives that invert platform power dynamics, prioritising societal benefit and civic agency over extraction and market logics. Meaningful digital sovereignty demands moving beyond platform exodus toward building hybrid public digital ecologies where democratic deliberation flourishes.

Pedro Burity, Rafael Grohmann, Kenzo Soares Seto & Rafael De Toni

Failures of digital sovereignty: different approaches within the Brazilian government. Since 2023, Brazil's federal government under Lula da Silva has increasingly centralised political discourse around digital sovereignty, aligning itself with broader international policy debates on the topic (Couture & Toupin 2019). This paper examines how two public enterprises linked to the Brazilian government—Serpro and DataPrev—have been engaging with, and failing at, practices of digital sovereignty. We argue that, in a context in which Big Techs are actively selling "sovereignty as a service" (Grohmann & Barbosa 2025), governments are attempting, but ultimately failing, to address the needs of digital sovereignty. We conceptualise these failures along two dimensions: first, as the persistent infrastructural dependency on Big Tech despite official sovereignty-oriented rhetoric; and second, as failure in the sense of malfunction or 'glitch', grounded in STS frameworks (Krapp 2011). In both cases, these failures update, in different ways, historical forms of dependency (Marini 2022). Based on an analysis of cloud computing and data governance projects developed by these two companies, alongside interviews with their representatives, the paper shows that Serpro articulates a discourse of sovereignty while simultaneously purchasing "sovereignty services" from Amazon. DataPrev, by contrast, is attempting to build its own infrastructure and takes pride in maintaining public data centres, yet its systems remain slow and prone to recurrent glitches, leading the company, in moments of urgency, to rely once again on Big Tech infrastructures. DataPrev has also begun partnerships with Chinese Big Tech firms, such as Huawei, in artificial intelligence projects. The paper reflects on these failures of digital sovereignty as, in one case, the result of political contingencies, and in the other, of technical contingencies. It also demonstrates how Brazil has become a strategic terrain of dispute between US and Chinese Big Tech companies, and how the Brazilian government is attempting to navigate this renewed condition of dependency through diplomatic and infrastructural strategies. References Couture, S., & Toupin, S. (2019). What does the notion of "sovereignty" mean when referring to the digital? New Media & Society, 21(10), 2305–2322. Grohmann, R., & Costa Barbosa, A. (2025). Sovereignty-as-a-service: How big tech companies co-opt and redefine digital sovereignty. Media, Culture & Society, Online First. Krapp, P. (2011). Noise channels: Glitch and error in digital culture. University of Minnesota Press. Marini, R. M. (2022). The dialectics of dependency. Monthly Review Press.

State & Private Entanglements

Bidisha Chaudhuri & Sookthi Kav

Digital Public(/Private) Infrastructures?: A case of Unified Payment Interface in India Digital Public Infrastructures (DPIs) are the new buzzword in the international policy circles. They typically include state-initiated large-scale infrastructural projects meant to operate at societal scale, creating collaborative ecosystem between state and market (Wood, Bunnel and Kong 2023). While the term DPI is rather new and lacks consensus, as a collective vision, it promotes creating digital infrastructure of identity, payment and data as three fundamental blocks on which any services could be mounted. Thus, digitally infrastructuring public services implies creating something akin to physical infrastructures of highways that could connect different sectors and domains of digital products, services and data. Building up such an infrastructural network requires reconfiguration of institutions, technologies and policies/regulation which remains beyond the solitary capacity of either the state or the market (Mazzucato 2018). However, the specific ways in which state and market collaborate differs from one context to another which further shape the constitutive norms and practices of the infrastructure. In this paper, I explore the case of Unified Payment System (UPI) of India to examine the specific nature of the state-market collaboration. Drawing on content analysis of policy documents, media reports, industry reports and qualitative interviews (n=15) of experts involved in the vison and development of the payment infrastructure, I trace the shared vision of the infrastructure, skills and interests of the main actors involved in curating this vison and their interpersonal and inter-organizational relationships that solidified the vision, and finally, the specific configuration of institutional, technological and regulatory capacities of these actors in enacting the infrastructural vision. The aim of this paper is to show how such collaboration blurs the line of what is typically considered to be public and/or private thus ushering in a new regime of public-private partnership model in public services. References: Mazzucato, M. (2018). The entrepreneurial state. Penguin Books. Woods, O., Bunnell, T., & Kong, L. (2023). The state-led platformisation of financial services: Frictionless ecosystems and an expansive logic of "smartness" in Singapore. Geoforum, 146, 103849.

Siddharth de Souza, Emrys Schoemaker & Thomas Kirk

Defining DPI Governance Siddharth Peter de Souza, Emrys Schoemaker and Thomas Kirk Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), primarily digital ID systems, data exchange systems and digital payment systems, have emerged as increasingly popular approaches by Governments across the world wishing to pioneer state led digitalization projects. They are variously described as akin to roads, rails, and other public utilities to emphasize their criticality to the emergence of state led digitalization projects. Along with the technical development of DPI, the international community is increasingly interested in the governance of DPI. This is evidenced by the creation of international standards like the DPI Safeguards from UNDP, at global convenings like the DPI Summit where the public value of DPI is debated, and in announcements by multilateral bodies such as the G20 that have sought to provide guidelines for countries deploying these technologies . More knowledge of how DPI can be governed in the public interest is crucial to addressing contemporary anxieties over transformational technologies from AI to data sharing arrangements. This includes fear that private actors at the forefront of their development will become de facto authorities as governments and civil society struggle to keep up with the pace of change. And that states and other actors will use them for ends such as social scoring, surveillance and selective exclusions from access to services. Our paper makes two critical contributions to the emerging DPI governance field. Firstly, we provide a landscape overview of different governance approaches to DPI from national, regional, and transnational actors. Secondly, and uniquely, we draw from our experiences of working with international organizations to research and support 'multi-stakeholder' approaches to DPI governance, and to develop and design model governance assessment frameworks for DPI. In doing so, we hope that this contribution will surface, as well as offer a typology of what DPI governance is, and what kinds of future directions are possible.

Dominik Piétron

Digital privatisation. Conflicts over data and platforms in public services in Germany. Online platforms form the central infrastructure of digital society and are triggering profound structural changes in many industries in the private sector. However, little attention has been paid to the fact that they have also impacted state and municipal actors in public service areas such as housing, health, education and mobility, who are increasingly coming into contact with private platform companies. This contribution uses a comparative field analysis of local public transport and the rental housing market in Germany as a case study to examine the structural effects of platformisation in public services. It focuses on how the economic coordination of basic goods and services is changing as a result of platform technology and the associated technopolitical conflicts. The study shows that digital public services are undergoing a double privatisation. On the one hand, private platform companies with profit-oriented business models are expanding into core public services. They circumvent regulations and artificially restrict data in order to generate value from these services. Secondly, many local authorities are attempting to set up their own public platforms, outsourcing this task to private service providers. These digital public–private partnerships also use proprietary software, resulting in negative effects such as technological dependency, high duplicate costs, and bureaucratic dysfunction. However, strategies for overcoming this dilemma are already emerging. Local and national organisations are identifying shared needs and pooling their resources to develop joint platform software for public authorities. They are also regaining control over private platform companies by demanding access to their data and monitoring their compliance with local regulations. Nevertheless, there is significant potential to enhance the informational self-determination of individuals and collectives, thereby safeguarding the public, welfare-oriented nature of digital infrastructure.

Clara Iglesias Keller & Julia Pohle

Working title: "The role of procurement in digital government initiatives: rethinking public data governance in light of digital self-determination" Digital government initiatives increasingly hinge on complex data infrastructures procured from private actors, raising core questions about digital sovereignty and statecraft in a rapidly shifting geopolitical and technological landscape. While literature on public data governance commonly focuses on the handling of data, this paper argues that software procurement, often treated as an administrative or technical formality, is in fact a formative moment in the configuration of digital sovereignty goals. It is during procurement that states exercise (or relinquish) infrastructural power, define long-term data flow and dependencies, and negotiate accountability structures and democratic standards that should underpin digital governance. We approach public data governance beyond organizational frameworks (Benfeldt et al 2020), encompassing the configuration of power relations, norms and socio-technical arrangements through which data collected under public mandate is accessed, controlled, shared and monetized. To illustrate this, the paper draws on the contrasting procurement trajectories of two German Covid-19 contact tracing systems: the publicly oriented, open-source Corona-Warn-App (CWA) and the vendor-driven luca App. We highlight three dimensions of procurement dynamics central to data governance and digital sovereignty efforts. First, procurement determines degrees of privatization: architectural control, access rules and monetization pathways were public in the CWA but vendor-centred in luca. Second, procurement opens or forecloses alternative, inclusive and participatory arrangements for public data governance; the CWA incorporated public debate, open standards and expert communities, whereas luca entrenched opaque, proprietary governance. Third, procurement influences legitimacy and public trust, which are crucial for the efficiency of digital government initiatives (Cingolani 2023). By analysing procurement as a strategic and normative moment of digital government initiatives, the paper contributes to debates on public data governance in light of digital self-determination, the political economy of digital statecraft, and emerging forms of data-based infrastructural power of the state. References: Benfeldt, Olivia, John Stouby Persson, and Sabine Madsen. 2020. "Data Governance as a Collective Action Problem." Information Systems Frontiers 22(2): 299–313. doi:10.1007/s10796-019-09923-z. Cingolani, Luciana. 2023. "Infrastructural State Capacity in the Digital Age: What Drives the Performance of COVID -19 Tracing Apps?" Governance 36(1): 275–97. doi:10.1111/gove.12666.

Citizens, Users & Citizenship

Rachel Humphris & Nika Mahnič

Digital deservingness: performing statecraft through bordering the welfare/workfare state. Across Europe, automated decision making systems and interoperable databases underpin welfare provision and migration control, creating a technological infrastructure that links internal and external bordering within and beyond the nation-state. This paper builds a conceptual bridge between digital welfare state research (Eubanks, 2017; Dencik and Kaun, 2020; Dencik, 2022) and digital migration studies (Maxwell and Tomlinson, 2022), drawing on critical citizenship theory (Goldberg, 2007; Shilliam, 2018). It argues that both 'failed citizens', (imagined as unable to meet liberal ideals (Anderson, 2013:2)) and non-citizens are organised through a shared moral economy centred on deservingness and contribution. The paper approaches this through digital deservingness: a datafied moral order through which welfare recipients and migrants become classifiable and governable (Dencik et al., 2019; Amoore, 2023). Welfare-AI systems extend border logics into welfare administration by sorting individuals via behavioural proxies and predictive risk scores. These practices reproduce hierarchies of worth and belonging while reframing citizenship as conditional and continuously verifiable. Simultaneously, migration management technologies draw on welfare datasets and identification systems, embedding external border priorities within domestic institutions. Together, these developments show how digital government performs statecraft by collapsing distinctions between social policy and migration control. The paper makes two contributions. First, it reconceptualises the digital welfare state as a site of internal bordering, where welfare eligibility operates as an instrument of external statecraft with international effects. This involves connecting data infrastructures of new public analytics (Yeung, 2022; Taylor, 2022) to moral economies of contribution and conditionality. Second, by situating digital government within intertwined moral and political economies, it reframes welfare infrastructures as terrains not only of extraction and discipline but also of contestation and possibility (Bradley and DeNoronha, 2022). Alternative municipal and civic infrastructures, including sanctuary city initiatives (Humphris, 2025), offer glimpses of alternatives against Big Tech 'solutions'.

Zhou Pei

What could be Techno-city politics?—— Analysis of Huawei's urban solution in Kenya This paper analysis the Safe City project in Kenya through a socio-technical and infrastructural politics perspective, treating Huawei's system not merely as a technological product but as an assemblage that reconfigure governance, security and civil agency in post colonial urban environment. The analysis draws on news reports, government and company press releases, academic studies on ICT development in Kenya, and research on Kenyan social dynamics and urban governance. The first section reviews the technological components and system designs of Safe City (eLTE installations) within the broader smart-city discourse (IoT, cloud computing, AI). Despite differences in purpose and functionality and core components, both models share a continuous assumption that urban governance is primarily a matter of innovative design and technological empowerment. The second section examines Kenya's social context in recent years, emphasising the complex condition that create demands for technological solutions. In the third section, I argue for a model of "meaningful international cooperation" that shifts from techno-centric to social-centric approaches, requiring customised, context-sensitive governance rather than imported patterns and universal toolkits. Finally, drawing on civil society contestation in Kenya, the paper highlight the urgency of transparent, inclusive regulatory processes. How to govern "governance technologies", protect civil society agency while reducing violence, and ensure that digital systems genuinely serve local communities are questions that demand global attention.

Oisín O'Brien

The Blameless state: When a digital solution becomes a forced option in "e-Estonia". Estonia is often cited as a place where digital and social systems intersect. Branded 'e-Estonia' for over 20 years, it introduced electronic identification and digital ID cards in 2002. Estonia's digital reputation has been widely publicised and is now part of nationalist rhetoric. But what happens when people struggle to access these "simple digital services?" Who is to blame? In a digital basics class for seniors in Tallinn, a student says it is her fault for not keeping up, and that she wishes to become a "nuti vanaema" (digitally equipped grandmother). Instead, she seeks the help of this class and her grandson (a reluctant digital mediator). In the network, a citizen is blamed for failing to display competent digital behaviour and for not following the "e-Estonia" script (Akrich, 1992). The Estonian state, meanwhile, preaches that it is creating new e-governance services to "empower all citizens" as it attempts to construct "responsible digital subjects"(Isin and Ruppert, 2020). With fewer options to complete appointments in person and fewer options to navigate digital services in Russian (the mother tongue of more than a quarter of citizens), citizens are left with the forced option(James, 1956) of using services they don't understand through the help of reluctant digital mediators/intermediaries. I argue that the forced option of digital public services in Estonia allows the state to assume a blameless position. In response to this, I elaborate on the informal networks of care that are necessary to sustain the very high levels of uptake of digital governance solutions in Estonia. Additionally, I explore how the endless media coverage of the success of e-Estonia means that the country cannot fail. Even in instances of objective failure – the ROCA chip card scandal 2017 – the state immediately mobilises it toward narratives of success. This paper uses ethnographic intervention and textual analysis to argue that the Estonian state presents itself as blameless for digital exclusion, while elderly and Russian minority citizens who do not fit the narratives of e-Estonia are blamed for their own exclusion. Key Words: Digital ID, e-governance services, Digital Exclusion, Estonia, Blame. Bibliography: Akrich, M. (1992) "The De-Scription of Technical Objects," in W.E. Bijker and J. Law (eds.) Shaping technology/building society: studies in sociotechnical change. Cambridge, Mass: MIT Press (Inside technology), pp. 205–225. Isin, E. and Ruppert, E. (2020) Being Digital Citizens. Second Edition. London & New York: Rowman & Liltlefield. James, W. (1956) The Will to Believe, and Other Essays in Popular Philosophy. Dover Publications.

Keren Weitzberg, Margie Cheesman, Aaron Martin, Hanna Stoll & Isadora Dullaert

This paper examines how Europe's digital identity infrastructure reorders the governance of membership, mobility, and rights through a comparison of the European Digital Identity Wallet (EUDI) and the European Asylum Dactyloscopy Database (Eurodac). Extending Lydia Morris's concept of 'civic stratification' to the digital domain, we show how identity systems function as tools of political ordering that

differentially position citizens and non-citizens within Europe’s digital governance landscape. The EUDI wallet frames EU citizens as digitally mobile subjects endowed with market-oriented data rights—voluntary participation, decentralized credential management, and selective disclosure—designed to facilitate cross-border circulation. In contrast, Eurodac governs asylum seekers and irregular migrants through mandatory, centralized biometric registration that prioritizes traceability and administrative control over data agency. Drawing on legal analysis, ethnographic fieldwork, and policy document review, we identify three dimensions of digital civic stratification: (1) divergent constructions of Europe as a space of circulation or restriction; (2) contrasting governance models that distribute control to users in some contexts while consolidating it within state authorities in others; and (3) tiered digital rights that position citizens as active participants in digital government while rendering migrants objects of data management. We argue that digital identity infrastructures actively reconfigure European sovereignty by shaping how authority, borders, and belonging are exercised.

James Rosenberg

Title: “If you don’t have SingPass, you don’t have citizenship”: Digital Government in Singapore Abstract: How does digitalization shape relations between states, markets, and citizens? To explore this question, I offer a case study of Singapore’s Smart Nation digital government initiative. While the city-state has been pursuing digitalization for over a decade, it has attracted relatively little scholarly attention. Drawing on archival research, ethnographic fieldwork, and interviews with government officials, policy experts, academics, and activists, I seek to address this lacuna. I follow Somers (2008) in thinking that one should attend to each element in the triad of state, market, and citizen when studying political-economic transformations. Consequently, I focus on how Singaporean digital initiatives link digital identity and digital payment systems in its "Singpass" app. As state, market, and citizen meet at this payment-identity nexus, it is an ideal site to study the way digitalization affects them. I attend to the ways that pursuing and justifying these initiatives affects relationships among actors and institutions, shaping the theory and practice of governance, and thereby producing new institutional configurations and capacities. This allows me to grapple with a disquieting question: What type of society emerges from a system wherein, as a leading Singaporean sociologist informed me, opting out of digital government means “you don’t have citizenship”? These developments are not just relevant to Singaporeans. As an “emerging global city” (Portes and Armony 2022), Singapore has actively exported its digital initiatives to other ASEAN nations (Somasundram 2018), and has served as a policy exemplar for Britain (Slobodian 2023), China (Ortmann and Thompson 2014), and the United States (Rosenberg, forthcoming). This suggests that as societies shift in a “postliberal” direction (Borg 2023), the Singaporean model of governance may serve as a harbinger of things to come.